

The Unrefusable Yes

Toward a Theory of Volitional Horror
in Curry Barker's *Obsession*

A DISSERTATION IN EIGHT CHAPTERS

MMXXVI

Contents

	Abstract	3
	Introduction · *The Optative Turned Imperative*	5
I	Genealogies of the Granted Wish	9
II	Mythic Prototypes of Compelled Love	15
III	Arboreal Semiotics of the Willow	21
IV	The Phenomenology of Coerced Love	26
V	Psychoanalysis of the Realized Fantasy	36
VI	Horror-Theoretical Coordinates and the Comparative Corpus	44
VII	Entitlement, Recognition, and the Political Economy of Devotion	51
VIII	The Original Thesis: Volitional Horror and the Unrefusable Yes	57
	Conclusion · *The Dignity of the No*	66
	Works Cited	68
	Keywords	74

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ABSTRACT

THIS dissertation argues that Curry Barker's *Obsession* (Toronto International Film Festival, 5 September 2025; U.S. release, 15 May 2026) is the paradigmatic text of an emergent mode it names *volitional horror*: a horror whose monstrous object is neither a deformed body (body horror) nor a body colonized by an alien spirit (possession horror), but a will from which the capacity for refusal has been removed. Bear Bailey's wish, enacted by snapping a novelty talisman called the One Wish Willow, that his friend Nikki Freeman love him more than anyone in the world, converts the optative mood into an imperative addressed to reality. It thereby manufactures what this study calls the *unrefusable yes*: an assent emptied of the live possibility of dissent, and therefore emptied of assent itself. Against readings that locate the film's horror in the excess, falsity, or demonic provenance of Nikki's love, the study locates it in *authorship*. The love is real, as the film's corporate oracle insists; what is unbearable is that it is real and authored by another.

The argument proceeds through eight chapters. Chapter I reconstructs the genealogy of the granted wish, from the folktale type ATU 750A, Cazotte's *Le Diable amoureux*, and the cat-familiar of the 1566 Chelmsford pamphlet, through W. W. Jacobs's "The Monkey's Paw," John Collier's "The Chaser," and the *Simpsons* parody Barker names as his catalyst. It shows that the film relocates the curse from the object to the content of the wish, converting cosmic irony into an ethics of the optative. Chapter II assembles the mythography of compelled love: Medea's Eros-implanted passion, Helen's phantom double, Pygmalion's statue, Daphne's nodding laurel, Echo's borrowed voice, Tristan's philtre, and Shakespeare's never-disenchanted Demetrius. Chapter III decodes the willow as an overdetermined emblem of captivity, mourning, forsaken love, femicide, analgesia, and Stendhalian crystallization. Chapters IV and V submit the wish to the philosophy of recognition and autonomy (Hegel, Rousseau, Kant, Sartre, Levinas, Murdoch, Frankfurt, Christman, Mele, Darwall) and to psychoanalysis (Freud, Abraham and Torok, Winnicott, Lacan, Žižek, de Rougemont, Bataille,

Kristeva). Chapter VI situates the film within horror theory (Carroll, Wood, Clover, Creed, Mulvey, Williams, Fisher, Cavell) and a comparative corpus running from Hoffmann's Olimpia and du Maurier's Svengali to *Get Out*, *Ruby Sparks*, *Midsommar*, and *Weapons*. Chapter VII reads the wish as the limit-technology of male affective entitlement and of a palliative, algophobic culture (Manne, Srinivasan, Illouz, Badiou, Han, Heidegger, Zuboff).

Chapter VIII states the original thesis as four theorems. The *theorem of provenance*: horror attaches to alien authorship, not to involuntariness. The *theorem of the superlative*: a love compelled to rank one person above all others manufactures rivals, so that its violence is grammatical before it is psychological. The *theorem of the inverted message*: the wisher receives his wish returned, as Dantean *contrapasso*. The *theorem of the remainder*: the abolished No survives as scream, self-defacement, and somniloquy, and restored autonomy inherits deeds it did not author. The film's title proves diagnostic rather than descriptive. What Bear undergoes and enacts is *obsessio*, the besieging of a will from without; what he inflicts is *possessio*, its occupation from within.

Yes

INTRODUCTION

The Optative Turned Imperative

Whosoever looketh on a woman to lust after her hath committed adultery with her already in his heart.

Matthew 5:28 (King James Version)

1 The object and its occasion

OBSESSION is the second feature written, directed, and edited by Curry Barker (b. 1999, Mobile, Alabama), co-founder with Cooper Tomlinson of the sketch-comedy channel *that's a bad idea*, whose found-footage slasher *Milk & Serial* (2024) was made for roughly eight hundred dollars and released free on YouTube (Curry Barker, Wikipedia). Shot in the Los Angeles area in late 2024 for at most $750,000, the film premiered in the Midnight Madness programme at Toronto on 5 September 2025. Focus Features acquired it for a reported $14–15 million, the highest price yet paid for a genre title at that festival, released it in the United States on 15 May 2026, and saw it gross more than $370 million worldwide by the end of June, making it the studio's highest-grossing release (*Obsession*, Wikipedia). Its second- and third-weekend increases, driven by an audience three-quarters of which was aged eighteen to thirty-four, mark it as a generational document as much as a commercial anomaly.

The film's genesis is instructive. Barker first conceived a story about a couple mutually obsessed with one another; the wish-mechanism arrived in July 2023, when he caught a rerun of *The Simpsons*' "Treehouse of Horror II" (1991), whose opening segment parodies the monkey's paw. He reportedly declined a $2 million offer to rewrite the script so as to make Bear a hero. He deliberately withheld both Nikki's backstory and the lore of the talisman, designed the Willow with his mother, a graphic designer, and accepted from his father, a playwright, the monologue in which Nikki recites a violent and incestuous "Hansel and Gretel." An original ending modelled on *Romeo and Juliet*, in which Nikki kills herself upon release from the wish, was replaced by one in which she survives (ibid.). Each decision (the refusal of heroism, the withholding of lore, the folk-tale interpolation, the cancelled *Liebestod*) will prove to be a structural commitment rather than an anecdote.

2 The fable

Baron "Bear" Bailey works at a family-owned music store with his childhood friend Nikki Freeman and their friends Ian and Sarah Harper, daughter of the owner, Carter. The film opens on a rehearsal: in a diner, Bear practises a confession of love on a waitress standing in for Nikki while Ian directs. Returning home, he finds his cat, Sandy, dead from oxycodone left within reach. Shopping for a gift for Nikki in a crystal shop, he buys a One Wish Willow, a novelty that grants one wish per person when snapped. That night Nikki asks him directly whether he likes

her; he denies it. Alone, he breaks the Willow and wishes that she love him more than anyone in the world. She returns at once, invents a dying father, kisses him in his bed, then screams and recoils.

What follows is a domestic idyll curdling into atrocity. Nikki builds a memorial from Sandy's remains, attributes her strangeness to MDMA, keeps vigil over Bear's sleep, and later feeds him a sandwich made from the cat. Bear learns that before the wish she had described him to Sarah as a little brother, and that she and Ian had been sleeping together for two years. A call to the Willow's customer-service line yields a bored, omniscient voice, Barker's own, which informs him that the wish expires only with his death and then patches through the screaming of a Nikki who is somewhere else. At a party Nikki recites the "Hansel and Gretel" monologue, displaces Sarah from a dare, kisses Bear, screams, and turns a broken bottle on her own face. With the possessing persona sedated into sleep, the real Nikki surfaces and begs Bear to kill her; he refuses, wounded that she would prefer death to him. Nikki murders Sarah with a brick, later wears her dress and scalp, and shoots Ian, who has used his own wish to make a billion dollars fall from the ceiling. Barricaded in a bathroom, Bear cannot shoot himself, swallows the remaining oxycodone, and is trying to vomit it up when Nikki snaps the last Willow. Compelled in turn, he walks out, kisses her, and dies. With his death the first wish lapses; the real Nikki returns with a gun in her hand and a corpse in her lap, and the film ends on her howling (*Obsession*, Wikipedia).

3 Method

The study reads the film at the level Umberto Eco called the *intentio operis*, the intention of the work as a coherent semiotic system, rather than the *intentio auctoris*, while treating authorial testimony as evidence rather than verdict (Eco 1992). Where Barker's glosses and the film diverge (he has insisted in one interview that *Obsession* is not a possession film, and conceded in another that it depicts possession of an unusual kind, not by a demon but by Nikki's own desires), the divergence is itself treated as data. The comparative method is constellational in Walter Benjamin's sense: texts separated by millennia are juxtaposed not to assert influence but to let a configuration disclose what no element contains (Benjamin 1928). The philosophical method follows Stanley Cavell's conviction that a film can think, and that a genre can conduct a sustained argument about the conditions of human acknowledgment (Cavell 1979; 1981).

Three protocols govern the evidence. First, onomastic and iconographic readings (of a heroine surnamed Freeman, a protagonist christened Baron, a shop named for the Green Man) are offered as constellational resonances with explicitly limited evidentiary weight, and never as claims about design. Second, screenplay material is cited only where it has been publicly reported, and plot claims are anchored to published synopses and frame-level analyses. Third, the analysis declines the comfortable assumption that the film's restriction to Bear's perspective is either a simple failure or a simple critique; Chapter VI treats that restriction as the film's most contested formal decision.

4 Thesis and architecture

The central claim is that *Obsession* isolates, with a purity the genre has rarely achieved, a fourth locus of horror. Body horror deforms the flesh; possession horror installs an alien tenant in it; the horror of mesmerism and mind control subjects the will to a stranger. *Obsession* subjects the will to a *lover*, to one who professes and perhaps even feels devotion to his victim, and makes that devotion the very instrument of occupation. This mode is here named *volitional horror*, and its constitutive product the *unrefusable yes*. Read against the demonological distinction between *obsessio*, the besieging of a soul from without, and *possessio*, its occupation from within, the title becomes a diagnosis of the wisher rather than a description of the beloved. Bear's obsession is the siege; Nikki's possession is its success.

Four theorems, established in Chapter VIII, organize the conclusions. The *theorem of provenance* holds that the horror of compelled love attaches not to its involuntariness, since all love is to some degree involuntary, but to its authorship by another will. The *theorem of the superlative* holds that a love compelled to rank one person above all others must treat all others as rivals. The *theorem of the inverted message* holds, with Lacan, that the wisher receives his message back in inverted form. The *theorem of the remainder* holds that the abolished No cannot be abolished but only displaced into symptom, and that autonomy restored inherits deeds it did not author. A corollary, the *ethics of the optative*, follows: in a world where wishes are efficacious, the morality of fantasy becomes the morality of action. Chapters I through VII assemble the genealogies on which these theorems rest.



CHAPTER ONE

Genealogies of the Granted Wish

Che vuoi?

What do you want?

Jacques Cazotte, *Le Diable amoureux* (1772)

1.1 The folk grammar of wishing

THE wish-tale is among the oldest moral technologies of narrative. The Aarne–Thompson–Uther index catalogues it as ATU 750A, *The Wishes*: a poor couple, granted three wishes as reward or test, squander the first on a trivial appetite, spend the second in anger (in Perrault's "Les Souhaits ridicules," 1693, a sausage grafted onto the wife's nose), and expend the third undoing the second. The tale's grammar is triadic and restorative: wish, catastrophe, unwish. Its moral is that desire, granted unmediated access to the world, exposes its own triviality or violence, and that the highest use of omnipotence is to cancel itself.

Obsession conserves the first two terms and abolishes the third. Each person receives one wish; the wisher cannot buy a second; the only available revocation is death. Revocation becomes possible only through another's wish, and that wish, when it comes, is not a cancellation but a counter-imposition. The restorative grammar of the folktale is replaced by a grammar of irreversibility, which is the grammar of injury.

1.2 Pacts, demons, and familiars

Long before the monkey's paw, European literature imagined the procurement of love through supernatural agency, and consistently gendered the transaction: a man petitions a power, and a woman's heart is the commodity. In Marlowe's *Doctor Faustus* (c. 1592) the summoned Helen is a demonic simulacrum whose kiss Faustus begs to make him immortal, and whose lips, in the play's own image, "suck forth my soul"; the kiss of the conjured beloved is a kiss of death, as Bear's will be. Goethe's *Faust I* (1808) secures Gretchen through Mephistopheles' jewel-casket and ends in her infanticide, madness, and condemnation, the voices above the dungeon pronouncing her first judged (*gerichtet*) and then saved (*gerettet*). The Gretchen tragedy is the first great modern narrative in which the woman procured by a man's infernal bargain is left to bear the judicial consequences of the bargain, a structure *Obsession* revives in its coda.

Jacques Cazotte's *Le Diable amoureux* (1772) supplies the purest prototype. Alvare, a young captain in Naples, conjures the devil, who appears as a monstrous camel's head demanding *Che vuoi?* ("What do you want?") and then, at Alvare's command, assumes the form of Biondetta, a woman of perfect devotion who follows, serves, and adores him. Alvare's torment is epistemic: he cannot know whether the love addressed to him is love or a demon's performance of it. Lacan

later lifted Cazotte's *Che vuoi?* to the summit of his graph of desire as the question the subject receives from the Other (Lacan 1960). *Obsession* answers that question with catastrophic literalism. Bear knows exactly what he wants, says it, and receives Biondetta.

The English witchcraft pamphlets supply a vernacular analogue. The 1566 Chelmsford *Examination and Confession* records that Elizabeth Francis received from her grandmother a white spotted cat called Sathan, fed on bread, milk, and her blood, which granted her sheep, procured for her a man, Andrew Byles, and destroyed him when the procured union failed. The familiar is a wish-engine that procures bodies but cannot procure consent, and turns lethal at the precise point where the procured person refuses the role assigned. The feline coincidence carries no evidentiary weight, but it is suggestive: *Obsession* opens on a dead cat, and the Willow's packaging, by one frame-level account, bears a cat mascot (Film Colossus). The familiar is dead before the wish is made; the wish takes its place.

1.3 The monkey's paw and its parody

W. W. Jacobs's "The Monkey's Paw" (1902) gave the modern wish-tale its canonical form and its theology. The paw, Sergeant-Major Morris explains, was enchanted by an old fakir who "wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives, and that those who interfered with it did so to their sorrow." The talisman is a demonstration device in a theodicy: it proves the sovereignty of fate by punishing the presumption of the wisher. The Whites' first wish, for two hundred pounds, is granted as compensation for their son's death in factory machinery; the mother's second recalls the son from the grave; the father's third, uttered as the revenant knocks, returns the dead to death. Jacobs's horror is the horror of *perverse fidelity*: the paw grants exactly what is asked, by the worst available route. Stephen King's *Pet Sematary* (1983), which invokes Jacobs explicitly, Americanizes the structure into a problem of grief.

The *Simpsons* parody that Barker credits strips the structure to its comic mechanism. In "Treehouse of Horror II," a paw bought in a Marrakesh bazaar turns each family member's wish against them: Lisa's wish for world peace invites alien conquest, and Homer's wish for a turkey sandwich yields one that is slightly dry. The parody matters more than its slightness suggests. It reconceives the wish as a tourist purchase, a commodity with an exchange value and a souvenir's kitsch, and it is precisely this commodity form that Barker develops. The One Wish Willow is a novelty sold in a crystal shop, priced, boxed, and printed with a

customer-service number. When Bear calls that number, the numinous answers in the idiom of the call centre.

The scene inverts Max Weber's thesis of disenchantment (Weber 1919). Rationalization does not evacuate magic from the world; magic returns wearing rationalization's uniform. The voice on the line belongs to the order Kafka diagrammed in *The Castle* (1926), whose telephone connection to the authorities yields only distant humming and officials who explain nothing, and to the bureaucratic violence David Graeber analysed, in which procedural indifference is itself the form an institution's power takes (Graeber 2015). That the voice is Barker's own, recorded on his phone during the edit (*Obsession*, Wikipedia), gives the scene a reflexive charge: the author speaks as the bored administrator of the law his fiction has instituted.

1.4 Collier's chaser

The nearest literary ancestor of the premise, though Barker does not cite it, is John Collier's "The Chaser" (*The New Yorker*, 1940), adapted for *The Twilight Zone* in 1960. A young man buys a love potion from an old dealer for a dollar. The dealer promises that the beloved will want nothing but solitude and him, will be jealous of every hour he spends away, and will forgive even his straying. The dealer also stocks an undetectable poison, which he coyly calls a cleaner, at five thousand dollars, and the story's chill lies in his serene foreknowledge that the buyer will return for it once the love he has purchased becomes unendurable. Collier's insight is economic: the cure for compelled love is priced at the cost of a life, and the merchant profits on both ends of the transaction.

Obsession preserves the merchant's foreknowledge in the voice on the hotline, which seems to know Bear's wish before he states it, and preserves the price of the chaser, which is death. It removes only the commerce. No chaser is for sale; the only one available is the wisher's own death, and Bear, characteristically, tries to vomit it back up.

1.5 From cosmic irony to the ethics of the optative

The film's decisive innovation within this lineage is theological. Barker has rejected the assumption that the Willow is a cursed object: what is cursed, he said, is what Bear wishes for, namely "taking away someone's autonomy, taking away someone's self" (Dread Central). He noted that the crystal-shop employee has already used his wish and appears to have escaped unharmed, and the film shows

Ian's wish for money fulfilled without supernatural malice. The Willow, unlike the paw, is not a demonstration device in a theodicy of fate. It is a faithful instrument. Jacobs's paw is perverse; Barker's Willow is exact. The horror of the first lies in the route of fulfilment, the horror of the second in the content of the wish.

This relocation can be stated in Kantian terms with unusual precision. The *Groundwork* distinguishes what has a *price*, and so admits of an equivalent, from what has a *dignity*, and so admits of none (Kant 1785, 4:434–35). The film stages its two completed wishes on either side of that line. Ian's billion dollars belongs to the realm of price: fungible, countable, raining from the ceiling as pure equivalent. Bear's wish trespasses into the realm of dignity, the domain of what cannot be substituted, and the world's response is horror. *Obsession* is thus a fable in which the cosmos permits the rearrangement of things but not of persons, and in which the sole inviolable law of the Willow's universe coincides with the formula of humanity. Barker's remark that a world of working wishes ought to contain dragons (*Obsession*, Wikipedia) concedes the plot hole but confirms the metaphysics: the film is uninterested in what wishes can do to the world, and interested only in what one wish does to a person.

Speech-act theory sharpens the point. A wish is an optative utterance with what John Searle called a world-to-mind direction of fit: it represents a state of affairs the speaker would have the world conform to, without itself possessing power to bring that conformity about (Searle 1983). The Willow converts the optative into a perlocutionary act that bypasses every condition J. L. Austin identified as necessary for a performative to bind another (Austin 1962), above all *uptake*. Nikki is not the addressee of Bear's wish; she is its object. She is spoken about, never spoken to. Stephen Darwall has argued that moral claims are constitutively second-personal, addressed by one free and accountable agent to another and presupposing the addressee's standing to accept or reject them (Darwall 2006). The wish is the third-person operation par excellence, securing from Nikki a response that no second-person address could legitimately command. Its occasion is precisely Bear's flight from the second person. When Nikki asks him in the car whether he likes her, she opens the space in which love could be declared and declined; Bear denies, and only then, alone, reaches for the third-person instrument.

The Sermon on the Mount had already abolished, in the moral register, the distance between wish and deed: whoever looks on a woman to lust after her "hath committed adultery with her already in his heart" (Matthew 5:28). The Willow abolishes that distance in the physical register and so performs a thought-experiment of rare clarity. Remove the buffer between fantasy and act,

and the moral content of the fantasy stands exposed. This is the *ethics of the optative*: the film's claim that a wish is never innocent merely because it is impotent, and that what one wishes upon another reveals, with the force of a deed, what one is prepared to do.

II

CHAPTER TWO

Mythic Prototypes of Compelled Love

Ah ! encore moi.

Ah! Me again.

Jean-Jacques Rousseau, *Pygmalion* (1770)

2.1 Medea: the implanted passion

THE oldest fully articulated narrative of a love implanted for another's advantage is the third book of Apollonius of Rhodes's *Argonautica* (third century BCE). Hera and Athena, needing Jason to obtain the Golden Fleece, petition Aphrodite, who bribes her son with a golden ball to shoot Medea; the arrow burns beneath her heart like fire, and Medea, princess and priestess of Hecate, betrays her father and kills her brother for a stranger. The love is real in its phenomenology (Apollonius's portrait of Medea's sleepless deliberation is among the most intimate in ancient literature) and wholly heteronomous in its origin. Its beneficiary is a man who did not even have to ask.

Euripides' *Medea* (431 BCE) shows the debt coming due. When Jason trades her for the Corinthian princess, Medea sends the rival a poisoned robe and diadem that burn the flesh from her bones, then kills her own children. *Obsession* reproduces the structure with uncanny exactness and one telling inversion. The love is implanted for a man's benefit; its object proves lethal to a rival; the rival's garment is the vehicle of the violence. But where Medea sends a poisoned dress to the rival, Nikki takes the rival's dress, and the rival's scalp, and puts them on. The poisoned gift becomes a stolen skin.

2.2 Helen: the judgment, the encomium, and the eidolon

The Trojan cycle begins with a wish of the same grammatical type. Offered the gifts of three goddesses, Paris chooses neither Hera's dominion nor Athena's wisdom but Aphrodite's promise of the most beautiful woman's love, as the lost epic *Cypria* recounted. The Judgment of Paris is the archetypal wish to be loved, and it is not incidental that it destroys a civilization. Western literature has since debated whose love it was. Gorgias's *Encomium of Helen* (late fifth century BCE) exculpates her by enumerating the forces that might have moved her: the gods' will, physical force, persuasive speech, and Eros itself. If she was compelled by love, she is no more culpable than a captive. Gorgias's sophistry is the first philosophical theory of responsibility under erotic compulsion, and Chapter VIII returns to it when Nikki faces the law.

More uncanny still is the counter-tradition. Stesichorus, struck blind by legend for slandering Helen, recovered his sight by composing a *Palinode* denying that she ever went to Troy; Plato preserves its opening (*Phaedrus* 243a). Herodotus (2.112–20) and Euripides' *Helen* (412 BCE) elaborate the doctrine: the gods fashioned an *eidōlon*, a breathing phantom, which Paris took to Troy and over

which Greeks and Trojans slaughtered one another for ten years, while the real Helen waited, chaste and grieving, in Egypt.

Obsession's ontology is precisely this. Bear wins an *eidōlon*, what Katie Rife aptly calls a "volatile doppelgänger" (RogerEbert.com). The real Nikki is elsewhere, audible only as screaming down a telephone line, as the real Helen was recoverable only at the war's end. The film's terrible revision lies in the eidolon's function. Euripides' gods made the phantom to *protect* the real woman; Barker's wish makes it to *replace* her, and the original endures not in Egyptian sanctuary but, as the same review puts it in other words, in torment while her double cuddles the man responsible.

2.3 Pygmalion and the *encore moi*

Ovid's Pygmalion (*Metamorphoses* X.243–97) withdraws from women in disgust at the Propoetides, who denied Venus's divinity and were turned first into prostitutes and then into stone, and carves an ivory maiden more perfect than any woman born. At his prayer Venus animates her. Ovid's description of her first conscious moment is the founding image of the designed beloved: blushing at his kisses and raising her eyes to the light, she sees the sky and her lover together (*pariter cum caelo vidit amantem*, X.294). Her consciousness opens onto him; he is co-original with the world.

Rousseau's *Pygmalion* (written 1762, performed 1770), which named the statue Galathée, pushes the logic to its narcissistic conclusion. Touching herself, the awakened statue says *Moi*; touching marble, *Ce n'est plus moi*; touching Pygmalion's hand, she sighs *Ah! encore moi*, "Ah, me again." The beloved created by the lover's desire recognizes the lover as herself. Rousseau, who theorized *amour-propre* more searchingly than anyone, here stages its consummation: to be loved by a creature of one's own making is to be loved by oneself in another's body.

Obsession executes the fantasy in reverse. Pygmalion animates the inanimate into love; Bear petrifies the living into it. The ivory acquires a will; Nikki's will acquires the fixity of ivory. The film's practical makeup, influenced by a TikTok "uncanny valley" trend that subtly displaced the actress's features (*Obsession*, Wikipedia), materializes the petrification: the face is still Nikki's, but it has the faint wrongness of a likeness.

2.4 Daphne and the nod

The myth that most precisely anticipates the film's ethics is the first love story of the *Metamorphoses* (I.452–567). Cupid, slighted by Apollo, fires two arrows: a golden one that kindles love in the god, a leaden one that repels it in the nymph Daphne. Desire is induced, asymmetrically, by an external technology. Daphne flees; at the moment of capture she prays to her father to destroy the beauty that has made her a target, and becomes a laurel. Apollo, undeterred, embraces the trunk, feels the heart still beating beneath the bark, and claims the tree as his emblem. Then Ovid adds the most disquieting lines of the episode: the laurel nodded with its newly made branches and seemed to shake its crown as though it were a head (*factis modo laurea ramis / adnuit utque caput visa est agitasse cacumen*, I.566–67). *Adnuit* is the verb of assent; *visa est* ("seemed") carries the whole weight of the passage. A woman who has sacrificed her human form to escape a god's desire is credited, through a narration focalized by the god, with consenting to it.

This is the hermeneutic structure this study calls *Daphnean assent*: the reading of consent into the involuntary motion of a body whose capacity to refuse has been destroyed. Bear's conduct throughout the middle act is a sequence of Daphnean readings. He accepts the MDMA alibi; he interprets the kisses as love, the vigil as devotion, the jealousy as passion. He becomes the narrator for whom the laurel nods. The tree that seemed to nod and the toy willow that makes her say yes belong to a single arboreal mythology of manufactured consent, which Chapter III develops.

2.5 Echo

Ovid's Echo (*Metamorphoses* III.339–510), punished by Juno for her chatter, can only repeat the final words of others. When Narcissus, lost in the woods, calls "let us come together here" (*huc coeamus*), she answers *coeamus*, and Ovid observes that she would never answer any sound more gladly (III.386–87). Her assent is real, and it is also the mere return of his words. The episode isolates the phonetics of the unrefusable yes: a yes that is the speaker's own proposition reflected back. Rife's observation that the possessed Nikki's speech is halting, and the screenplay's reported direction that in one late sequence her lips should not match her words (Film Colossus), give Echo's curse a cinematic body. Narcissus completes the pair; Chapter V argues that Bear, who cannot look at himself in a mirror, needs Nikki to become one.

2.6 The philtre: Tristan, Titania, Demetrius, Orsino

Medieval romance moved the agency of compelled love from gods to pharmacology. In the Tristan legend (Béroul and Thomas in the twelfth century; Gottfried von Strassburg c. 1210), a potion brewed by Iseult's mother to bind her daughter to King Mark is drunk by mistake by Iseult and Tristan, who are thereafter bound to one another in adultery and, finally, in death. Denis de Rougemont's *L'Amour et l'Occident* (1939) reads the philtre as an alibi: it permits the lovers to experience passion as fate rather than choice, while the passion's secret object is not the beloved but the obstacle and, beyond the obstacle, death. Wagner's *Tristan und Isolde* (1865) consummates the logic in the *Liebestod*. Barker's discarded ending, modelled on *Romeo and Juliet*, would have granted *Obsession* a Liebestod; the theatrical ending denies it, and Chapter V argues that the denial is the film's most consequential formal decision.

Shakespeare's *A Midsummer Night's Dream* (c. 1595) supplies the comic counter-case and its unremarked scandal. Oberon's juice, distilled from the flower where "the bolt of Cupid fell," makes Titania dote on an ass and redirects the young Athenians' affections at random. The confusions are reversed, except one. Demetrius, who loved Hermia, is never released from the enchantment that turned him to Helena; he enters marriage under its influence, describing his former love as melted like snow. The comedy's festive closure rests on a permanent, unconsented enchantment that everyone agrees not to notice. *Obsession* is the horror-reading of Demetrius's fate: what the comedy sublimates into a wedding, the horror film follows into the bedroom, the kitchen, and the morgue.

Twelfth Night offers a quieter link. Orsino opens that play demanding an excess of music, the food of love, so that the surfeited appetite may sicken and die; he woos by proxy, through Viola. In *Obsession*, set in a music store, the crystal-shop employee who sells Bear his proxy-wooer is named Viola (*Obsession*, Wikipedia). Orsino's wish for a surfeit that kills appetite is the wish's secret logic: an excess of love administered so that desire itself may die.

2.7 Kiyohime, the *onryō*, and the yandere

The Japanese tradition offers the most developed iconography of female passion rendered monstrous. In the Dōjō-ji legend, recorded in the eleventh-century *Dainihonkoku Hokekyōkenki* and the *Konjaku Monogatarishū*, and dramatized in the Noh *Dōjōji*, the woman (later named Kiyohime) spurned by the young monk Anchin pursues him, transforms into a serpent, and burns him alive inside the

temple bell where he hides. The *onryō* tradition, culminating in Oiwa of Tsuruya Nanboku IV's *Yotsuya Kaidan* (1825), gives the wronged woman's love the force of a curse.

Contemporary otaku culture has distilled this lineage into the *yandere* archetype (from *yanderu*, "to be sick," and *deredere*, "lovestruck"): the girl whose devotion is total, whose jealousy is homicidal, and whose love is staged, crucially, as a *fantasy for the male viewer*, the romantic object who would kill for you. Sakae Esuno's *Mirai Nikki* (2006–10) and its Yuno Gasai are the canonical instance. *Obsession* is, in this light, an etiology of the yandere. It shows where she comes from: from a man's wish to be loved more than anyone in the world, granted. The archetype's appeal depends on bracketing the question of whose will produced such love. The film unbrackets it, and the fantasy collapses into horror.

2.8 The Song's adjuration

Against all of these, one ancient text states the counter-law with lapidary authority. Three times the Song of Songs adjures the daughters of Jerusalem "that ye stir not up, nor awake my love, till he please" (2:7; 3:5; 8:4); modern translations render the clause "until it please," making love itself the subject whose readiness must be awaited. Love must wake of its own accord; to rouse it by force is the prohibited act. The same book supplies the film's epigraph *avant la lettre*: "love is strong as death; jealousy is cruel as the grave" (8:6).

Obsession stages the adjuration's violation with a precision that seems almost liturgical. The wish awakens love before it pleases. And in the film's most harrowing scene, the real Nikki, speaking from a sedated body, inverts the adjuration: the thing awakened in her is asleep now, she warns, and must not be woken (Film Colossus). The sleeper's plea is the Song's law spoken from inside its transgression.

III

CHAPTER THREE

Arboreal Semiotics of the Willow

We hanged our harps upon the willows in the midst thereof.

Psalm 137:2 (King James Version)

3.1 The fracture

THE Willow is activated by being broken. The ritual descends from the wishbone, the furcula of a fowl pulled between two people until it snaps, the larger piece granting its holder a wish. The furcula is a zero-sum sacrament: one wish is granted precisely because another is denied. Two features of the folk practice illuminate the film. First, the wishbone requires two parties, its fracture being literally a contest of wills; Bear breaks his Willow alone, in his car, eliminating the second party whose resistance the ritual presupposes. Second, the wish is purchased by a fracture. In *Obsession* the fracture migrates from the object to the subject. What breaks, once the Willow is snapped, is Nikki.

The same gesture recurs, with striking independence, in Zach Cregger's *Weapons* (2025), released a month before *Obsession*'s premiere but made in the same period. Its witch, Gladys, binds a strand of a victim's hair around a twig from her thorny tree and snaps it, and the victim becomes her instrument (Den of Geek). Two of the decade's most successful horror films thus converged, without contact, on one sacrament of will-capture: the breaking of a stick. The convergence argues for a shared cultural imaginary in which the will has become breakable wood.

3.2 Persephone's grove and Orpheus's willow

The willow's first appearance in Western literature places it at the threshold of death. Circe tells Odysseus that at the edge of Ocean he will find the groves of Persephone, tall poplars and willows that lose their fruit (*Odyssey* X.509–10). The Homeric epithet *ōlesikarpos*, "fruit-losing," was read in antiquity as a reference to the willow's sterility, binding the tree to chastity and to the barren threshold of Hades. Pausanias, describing Polygnotus's lost painting of the underworld at Delphi, records that Orpheus sat in the grove of Persephone, holding his lyre in one hand and with the other touching the branches of a willow (10.30.6).

The constellation is extraordinary. Orpheus is the archetypal musician-lover, the man who descends to recover his beloved from the dead, who is granted her return on a single condition, and who loses her by failing to keep it. Bear is a music-store clerk who, having consigned the real Nikki to an underworld of his own making, telephones down into it, hears her screaming, and hangs up. His is a katabasis in reverse: not a descent to bring her back, but a retreat that leaves her there. Orpheus's failure was a failure of restraint; Bear's is a failure of nerve. Both men are found beside a willow.

3.3 Psalm 137: harps on the willows

"By the rivers of Babylon, there we sat down, yea, we wept, when we remembered Zion. We hanged our harps upon the willows in the midst thereof" (Psalm 137:1–2). The captors demand a song; the captives answer, "How shall we sing the LORD's song in a strange land?" The willow is here the tree on which music is suspended in captivity, the instrument of joy hung up because joy cannot be performed under compulsion. Linnaeus named the weeping willow *Salix babylonica* (1753) after this psalm, although the tree of the Babylonian riverbanks was probably the Euphrates poplar. The botanical misnomer is itself an allegory: a tree misnamed for captivity became the Western emblem of grief.

The psalm's logic, that true song cannot be extracted from a captive, is *Obsession*'s logic in erotic register. The family that owns the film's music store is named Harper, and the first person Nikki kills is Sarah Harper (*Obsession*, Wikipedia). Whether designed or not, the constellation of harps, willows, captivity, and silenced song is coherent. The love Bear demands is a song required by a captor, and the psalm had already declared what such a song is worth.

3.4 The willow of the forsaken: Desdemona and Ophelia

In early modern English the willow was the tree of the jilted. To "wear the willow" was to mourn a lost or faithless love, and the willow garland was its badge. Shakespeare twice binds the tree to the death of a woman destroyed by a man's economy of love. In *Othello* (IV.iii), on the night of her murder, Desdemona recalls her mother's maid Barbary, whose lover "proved mad / And did forsake her," and who died singing "a song of 'willow'"; Desdemona sings it herself ("Sing all a green willow") while preparing the bed in which her jealous husband will smother her. In *Hamlet* (IV.vii) Gertrude reports that "there is a willow grows aslant a brook," from whose boughs the mad Ophelia, garlanded with weeds, fell into the water and drowned.

The willow thus carries into English literature two archetypes of female destruction: the woman murdered by a man's jealousy, and the woman driven mad by men's plots. Elaine Showalter's "Representing Ophelia" (1985) traced how Ophelia's madness became the template for female insanity as spectacle for the male gaze, and *The Female Malady* (1985) showed how female "hysteria" was diagnosed into being by male authorities. *Obsession* reassigns these archetypes with a twist that generates much of its disturbance. Nikki is both Desdemona and Othello: the woman destroyed and the jealous agent of destruction, because the

jealousy that animates her is the man's, installed in her by his wish. Her "madness," meanwhile, is a male production with diagrammatic literalness. The willow's two Shakespearean daughters converge in a single body.

3.5 The Green Man

The crystal shop in which Bear buys the Willow was filmed at a real Burbank establishment called the Green Man (*Obsession*, Wikipedia). The name belongs to one of the most enigmatic motifs of medieval church sculpture: the foliate head, a human face sprouting or disgorging leaves and branches, christened "the Green Man" by Lady Raglan in a 1939 article in *Folklore*. Whatever the motif meant to its makers (vegetation spirit, emblem of resurrection, demon of fleshly nature), its image is that of a person overtaken by a plant: a face colonized by foliage, often with leaves pouring from the mouth where speech should be.

As a location the name is a found object rather than a design choice, and is offered only as a resonance. It is nonetheless an apt one. The shop that sells the wooden talisman is named for the image of a human being possessed by vegetation, and the talisman's effect is to turn a speaking face into something like the Green Man's: a mouth from which another's growth issues.

3.6 The analgesic tree: from salicin to oxycodone

The willow is also, literally, a drug. In 1763 the Reverend Edward Stone reported to the Royal Society that powdered willow bark relieved agues; its active glycoside, salicin, was isolated in 1828, and an acetylated derivative was marketed by Bayer from 1899 as aspirin. The willow is the ur-analgesic of modern pharmacology, and *Obsession* is saturated with analgesia. Sandy dies of oxycodone, an opioid first synthesized in 1916; Nikki's possessed affection is first explained away as MDMA, the so-called love drug; Bear dies of the same oxycodone that killed his cat. One frame-level reading notes that the pills had been prescribed to Bear's grandmother and infers that he had been taking them to numb his own pain (Film Colossus). The Willow belongs to this pharmacopoeia. It is an analgesic for the pain of unrequited love, or more precisely for the pain of *risking* rejection, which Bear avoids at the decisive moment by denying his feelings.

Derrida's "La pharmacie de Platon" (1968) unfolded the Greek *pharmakon*, at once remedy and poison, from Plato's account of writing in the *Phaedrus*. The love-philtre is a pharmakon in the strictest sense, and the Willow joins it: remedy

for the pain of another's freedom, poison of that freedom. Byung-Chul Han's diagnosis of contemporary algophobia, a generalized intolerance of pain that palliates every negativity, including the negativity of the Other (Han 2020), supplies the cultural frame that Chapter VII develops. The protagonist's name supplies the irony. He is called Bear, and he cannot bear it.

3.7 Stendhal's bough and the crystal shop

The most exact theoretical counterpart of the Willow is a bough. In *De l'amour* (1822) Stendhal explained the lover's idealization by an image from the salt mines near Salzburg: a leafless branch, stripped by winter, is thrown into an abandoned working and drawn out months later glittering with crystals, the twig itself no longer recognizable. He called the process *crystallization*. The lover's mind, drawing perfections from everything around it, deposits them on the beloved until she disappears beneath them. Crystallization is the lover's own labour, a projective work performed upon a person who remains free beneath it, and whose freedom is what eventually shatters the crystals.

Bear buys his bough in a *crystal* shop. The Willow is a bough designed to reverse Stendhal's process: instead of the lover crystallizing the beloved in his imagination, the beloved is compelled to crystallize the lover in hers. Stendhalian crystallization is a fiction the lover tells himself; the Willow forces the beloved to tell it, with no free subject beneath to shatter the crystals. The result is a love with no twig inside, all crystal and no branch. That is the eidolon of Chapter II described in mineralogical terms.

IV

CHAPTER FOUR

The Phenomenology of Coerced Love

… ich kann nicht lieben, weil ich will …

I cannot love because I will to.

Immanuel Kant, *Die Metaphysik der Sitten* (1797)

4.1 Lordship without struggle

THE wish fails first on Hegel's terms, because it procures recognition from a consciousness deprived of the independence that alone makes recognition worth having. In the *Phenomenology of Spirit* self-consciousness is desire, and desire, which consumes its objects, can be satisfied only by an object that performs its own negation, that is, by another self-consciousness: *das Selbstbewußtsein erreicht seine Befriedigung nur in einem andern Selbstbewußtsein* (Hegel 1807, §175). The dialectic of lordship and bondage (§§178–96) shows how satisfaction so obtained miscarries. Two self-consciousnesses stake their lives in a struggle for recognition; the one who fears death submits and becomes the bondsman; the victor, acknowledged by a consciousness he does not acknowledge in return, receives *ein einseitiges und ungleiches Anerkennen*, a recognition one-sided and unequal (§191), and discovers that the truth of his independence lies in the servile consciousness he despises.

Bear obtains lordship without the struggle. Hegel insists that freedom is proved only by staking one's life, and that whoever has not risked it may be recognized as a person without attaining the truth of recognition (§187). Bear risks nothing, not even the small death of a refusal: when Nikki asks him in the car whether he likes her, he declines the only struggle the situation offers. The wish then grants him the lord's position without the lord's combat, and with it the lord's impasse in chemically pure form. The devotion he receives issues from a bondswoman whose bondage he authored, and it can testify to nothing but a power that was never in question.

Alexandre Kojève's anthropological reading sharpened the point: human desire is desire directed at another desire, the wish to be desired, which is to say recognized as a value (Kojève 1947). What is desired in another's desire is precisely its otherness, the fact that it might have been withheld. A desire produced by one's own desire is not another's desire. It is one's own desire returned with a woman's face, and Rousseau's Galathée, touching her maker's hand and sighing *encore moi* (Chapter II), had already given the formula of what the Willow sells.

The middle act stages the dialectic's revenge. Wish-Nikki is no passive bondswoman: the wish installs in her the hunger for recognition that produced it. Bear wakes to find her watching him sleep, and she weeps and accuses him of not loving her (*Obsession*, Wikipedia). The struggle Bear refused at the outset therefore reappears inside the eidolon, and at the climax it is consummated as parody. Nikki snaps the last Willow, and the lord becomes the bondsman of his

bondswoman. Two compelled consciousnesses face each other, each the other's instrument, and the only life staked in this struggle for recognition is the one Bear has already swallowed.

4.2 Amour-propre and the grammar of preference

The wish's formula, that she love him more than anyone in the world, is Rousseau's definition of erotic amour-propre with its labour removed. In the fourth book of *Émile* (1762) Rousseau derives the passions of comparison from the demand to be loved: to be loved one must make oneself lovable, and to be preferred one must make oneself more lovable than another, *plus aimable que tout autre*, at least in the eyes of the beloved; from this come the first glances at one's fellows, the first comparisons with them, and *l'émulation, les rivalités, la jalousie*. Frederick Neuhouser has shown that amour-propre, the need to have one's worth affirmed in others' eyes, is for Rousseau neither simply vicious nor simply natural, but a malleable passion whose inflamed form seeks superiority rather than equal standing (Neuhouser 2008).

Bear's wish is inflamed amour-propre in its purest form, and it breaks Rousseau's genealogy at the decisive point. Rousseau's condition for preference is a reflexive labour, *se rendre plus aimable*, to make oneself more lovable. The wish demands the effect while skipping the making: it is preference without self-formation, the end of Émile's education obtained without the education. Rousseau's sequence then runs on unimpeded, but in another body. Preference installed by decree brings with it the comparative glance, the rivalry, and the jealousy that Rousseau deduced from it, and lodges them in Nikki. The jealousy that will smash Sarah Harper's head against a brick is Rousseau's deduction executed: preference, comparison, rivalry, homicide. Chapter VIII formalizes the sequence as the theorem of the superlative.

A second distinction explains what the wish was for. *Émile* separates dependence on things, which, having no morality, does no harm to freedom, from dependence on persons, which engenders all the vices, and through which *le maître et l'esclave se dépravent mutuellement* (Rousseau 1762, book II). The Willow attempts to convert the most unbearable dependence on a person, dependence on her uncertain love, into dependence on a thing: to make Nikki's love as reliable as gravity, a natural law of her heart. Rousseau's own political remedy was to make dependence on persons as impersonal as dependence on things through the rule of law. Bear parodies the remedy by legislating a private law over a single subject,

and Rousseau's prognosis follows to the letter. Master and slave corrupt one another, and at the end they exchange places.

4.3 The commanded inclination

Kant twice declares that what the Willow does cannot be done. The *Groundwork* reads the scriptural command to love one's neighbour, even one's enemy, as a command of practical rather than pathological love, because love as an inclination cannot be commanded (Kant 1785, 4:399). The *Doctrine of Virtue* is blunter: love is a matter of feeling, not of willing; *ich kann nicht lieben, weil ich will*, still less because I ought; a duty to love is therefore *ein Unding*, an absurdity, literally a non-thing (Kant 1797, 6:401).

The Willow realizes the Kantian *Unding* through a substitution that discloses its structure. Nikki does not love because she wills, nor because she ought; she loves because *he* wills. The impossibility Kant identified was that of a will commanding its own feeling. Bear circumvents it by having a second will command the feeling of the first, and the product is exactly a non-thing, the eidolon of Chapter II given its Kantian name. The consequence reaches further. In Kant's vocabulary every inclination is pathological, determined from without by sensibility, so love as inclination is always heteronomous. Yet ordinary heteronomy has no author; it is nature's. The Willow gives heteronomy a name and an address. This is the first formulation of the theorem of provenance: since no one loves because she wills, involuntariness cannot be what horrifies in compelled love; what horrifies is an involuntariness that someone authored.

4.4 The automaton and the third

Sartre's analysis of love in *Being and Nothingness* (1943, III.3.i) reads as a gloss on the wish written eight decades before it. The lover, Sartre argues, does not want to possess the beloved as one possesses a thing; he wants to possess a freedom as freedom. He wants to be chosen freely and necessarily at once, loved by a freedom that is somehow no longer free. The diagnosis includes a counterfactual that *Obsession* realizes: were the beloved transformed into an automaton, the lover would find himself alone. The lover's further demand, to be for the beloved the whole world, the limit beyond which her transcendence does not pass, is the wish's own formula.

The film dramatizes both halves of the analysis. First, solitude: after the wish Bear is lonelier than before, since the woman beside him is no one he knows, and

his friends close ranks against her; Ian protests her presence at his party, and Sarah warns Bear that she may be using him (*Obsession*, Wikipedia). Second, the third. Sartre observes that love is perpetually exposed to the look of a third party, under which the lovers become objects together and the absolute they tried to found becomes relative. The party is a machine for the third's gaze: in a drinking game, a drawn block dares Bear to kiss the person to his left, and that person is Sarah. Wish-Nikki's violence is directed, with Sartrean logic, at thirds. Sarah and Ian die not only as erotic rivals but as witnesses, the looks under which an absolute love stands revealed as relative and manufactured.

4.5 Insomnia, sleep, and the face

Levinas supplies the vocabulary for two of the film's most original images, the vigil and the self-inflicted wound. In *Time and the Other* (lectures of 1946–47) the erotic relation is the relation with alterity as such, with a mystery that cannot be grasped; its pathos consists in *une dualité insurmontable des êtres*, an insurmountable duality of beings (Levinas 1948). Simone de Beauvoir objected that Levinas's casting of the feminine as the absolutely Other asserted a masculine privilege while ignoring the reciprocity of subject and object (Beauvoir 1949). The objection bears directly on the film, since Bear's wish is an attempt to surmount the insurmountable from the masculine side. The result is not fusion but the disappearance of the other.

What appears in its place is the impersonal. *Existence and Existents* (1947) describes the *il y a*, the anonymous rustling of being without beings, whose privileged experience is insomnia: a vigilance in which it is not I who watch but the night itself. Wish-Nikki is insomnia incarnate. Her vigil over Bear's sleep (§4.1) is a watching without anyone watching, and one close reading infers that the imposed persona does not sleep at all (Film Colossus). Levinas's counter-concept is sleep, through which an existent withdraws from the anonymous, takes up a position, and becomes a subject. The film's boldest invention converts this ontology into plot. The real Nikki can speak, as distinct from scream, only when the imposed persona sleeps; then, through sleep-talk, the occupied woman begs to be killed (*Obsession*, Wikipedia). In *Obsession* sleep is the last free territory of the self, and the occupying will is a night that never closes its eyes.

The face is the other register. For Levinas the face resists possession, not by force but by expression, and its first word forbids murder (Levinas 1961). In "Reality and Its Shadow" (1948) he set against the face the image, the likeness that

petrifies expression into plastic form, as a statue arrests an instant that can never pass. The uncanny-valley makeup of the possessed sequences (Chapter II) converts Nikki's face from face into likeness. At the party, having displaced Sarah and kissed Bear, she screams and drives a broken bottle into her own face, in what one account describes as a suicide attempt by the briefly resurfaced Nikki (Nikki Freeman, Wikipedia). Read through Levinas, the gesture is not madness but grammar. A face that can no longer refuse in speech refuses by destroying the likeness that has replaced it. Self-defacement is the face's last expression.

4.6 Feeling and the between

Martin Buber's *I and Thou* (1923) resolves the paradox on which the film's metaphysics turns. The Thou, Buber writes, cannot be found by seeking; the relation to it is mutual and given, never procured, while the world of It is the world of experience and use. And he distinguishes love from feeling with a formula the film might have been built to test: *Gefühle wohnen im Menschen, aber der Mensch wohnt in seiner Liebe*, feelings dwell in a person, but a person dwells in his love. Feelings are had; love happens, and it happens between.

The distinction dissolves the scandal of the hotline. When Bear calls the Willow's customer-service line, the voice tells him: "Just because you chose this for her doesn't make it less real" (Collider). In Buber's terms the representative is right about the feeling and wrong about the love. The wish can install a feeling, which then dwells in Nikki as truly as any feeling dwells anywhere. It cannot create the between, the relation in which two persons dwell. The real Nikki states the distinction with the brevity of the wronged. Pleading from inside the sleeping persona to be killed, she hears Bear, wounded, ask what is so terrible about being with him, and answers, "I've never been with you, Bear" (Film Colossus). Her body has been with him for days; she has not. Bear understands "being with" as the co-presence of bodies, Nikki as the dwelling of two persons in a relation, and the film's central ontological dispute is fought out in a single exchange.

Stephen Darwall's second-person standpoint, invoked in Chapter I, is the juridical form of the same insight. Claims between persons presuppose the addressee's standing to accept or refuse them (Darwall 2006), and the wish, which never addresses Nikki at all, cannot produce a relation to which she is a party.

4.7 Fantasy, attention, distance

Iris Murdoch's moral psychology identifies the wish as the paradigmatic anti-moral act. Love, she wrote, is "the extremely difficult realisation that something other than oneself is real" (Murdoch 1959), and the moral life is a long labour of attention against the "fat relentless ego," whose consoling fantasies obscure other people (Murdoch 1970). Her central example is a mother-in-law, M, who, with no change in her daughter-in-law D's conduct, slowly corrects her vision of D through just and loving attention. For Murdoch moral change happens in the one who sees.

Bear inverts M's labour precisely. Rather than revising his vision of Nikki to meet her reality, he revises her reality to meet his vision. The opening announces the priority of fantasy over attention before the plot begins. In a diner Bear rehearses his confession to a waitress standing in for Nikki while Ian directs, and the rehearsal culminates in a vow to choose her over everything; one frame-level reading notes that the stand-in tries to offer advice and that Bear does not attend to her (Film Colossus). The stand-in is the film's first eidolon. *Obsession* opens with a substitute Nikki and ends with a substitute that has taken Nikki's body, and the wish is only the technological completion of the rehearsal.

Simone Weil supplies the positive counterpart: *aimer purement, c'est consentir à la distance*, to love purely is to consent to distance, to adore the distance between oneself and what one loves (Weil 1947). Imagination, in her account, is the filler of the void, rushing to occupy an emptiness that only reality, or grace, should fill. The wish is imagination armed. It refuses to consent to distance and abolishes it by the only means available, the abolition of the other's consent, because the distance Weil asks the lover to adore is nothing other than the beloved's freedom.

4.8 The unwilling lover

Harry Frankfurt's hierarchical model of the will names Nikki's condition exactly. "Freedom of the Will and the Concept of a Person" (1971) distinguishes first-order desires from second-order volitions, the desires about which of one's desires should move one to act. Frankfurt's unwilling addict desires the drug and wills not to be moved by that desire; when he takes it, he can say without paradox that a force other than his own has moved him, against his will. Nikki after the wish is an unwilling lover in exactly this sense. Her first-order desire for Bear is overwhelming; her second-order volition, audible in the scream that follows each kiss and articulate in her plea to be killed, repudiates it. The pharmacology traced

in Chapter III here acquires argumentative force. The wish acts on Nikki as an addiction administered by another.

Frankfurt's later work raises the stakes. In *The Reasons of Love* (2004) love is not a feeling but a configuration of the will, a structure of caring that no one adopts at will and that constitutes, through what Frankfurt calls volitional necessity, the identity of the one who loves. If what we love determines who we are, a love installed from without does not merely add a desire to a self. It forges a self. The film represents this with a literalism that might be mistaken for genre convention: the woman who loves Bear is visibly another person, with another gait, another voice, another face, because a person constituted by an alien love is an alien person.

4.9 Structural and historical autonomy

The wish also adjudicates a central dispute of contemporary autonomy theory. Structural or hierarchical accounts, descending from Frankfurt and qualified by Gerald Dworkin's requirement of procedural independence (Dworkin 1988), judge whether a desire is one's own by its present relation to the agent's reflective attitudes. Historical accounts deny that this suffices. John Christman made autonomy depend on whether the agent would not have resisted a desire's development had she attended to it (Christman 1991), and Alfred Mele's case of Ann and Beth made the point canonical. Beth, covertly re-engineered by neuroscientists to share the values of her colleague Ann, is structurally indistinguishable from Ann, yet intuitively not autonomous, because her values have the wrong history (Mele 1995).

Obsession is a Mele case realized, with a twist that strengthens the historicist conclusion. Wish-Nikki endorses her love wholeheartedly: she defends it, demands its reciprocation, and kills to protect it. On any purely structural account her love is her own, and only a historical account registers the wrong the film makes unbearable. But the film adds what the thought-experiment omits. Mele's Beth does not survive her re-engineering as a protesting witness; Nikki does. The original agent persists beneath the installed one, audible on the telephone and in sleep. The structural account is therefore refuted twice: diachronically, because the love has the wrong history, and synchronically, because its endorsement is not even the endorsement of the whole person. The first refutation grounds the theorem of provenance, the second the theorem of the remainder.

4.10 Consent at the hospital door

One scene submits consent theory to institutional light. Bear drives Nikki to a hospital and tries to have her admitted. In the released film the exchange is wordless, but the screenplay specifies that the nurse refuses to take her on the principle of informed consent (Film Colossus). In Ruth Faden and Tom Beauchamp's classic analysis, an autonomous authorization must be intentional, made with understanding, and free of controlling influences (Faden and Beauchamp 1986). The institution, applying the doctrine, honours Nikki's refusal of treatment. Yet that refusal plainly serves the wish, since admission would separate her from Bear.

The irony is exact. At the one moment an institution consults Nikki's will, it ratifies a refusal ventriloquized by her captor. Medicine possesses a procedure for honouring a *no*; it possesses none for detecting a manufactured *yes*, or a manufactured *no*, because its doctrine presupposes that the capacity to refuse, wherever exercised, belongs to the one exercising it. The condition of non-control, which every act of Wish-Nikki fails absolutely, is invisible from outside. The scene anticipates the film's legal coda: institutions read wills by their surfaces, and the Willow operates beneath the surface.

4.11 What the hotline gets right

The representative's sentence merits a final analysis, because it states with corporate flatness the thesis of this study. It severs two questions that romance keeps fused: whether a love is real, and whose it is. Cazotte's Alvare (Chapter I) was tormented by the first question, unable to know whether Biondetta's devotion was love or diabolical performance. Bear receives an answer, the answer is yes, and the answer makes everything worse. Ontological reassurance aggravates the horror instead of relieving it.

From this follows the theorem of provenance in its full form. All love is in some degree involuntary: one *falls* in love; Eros shoots; Kant concedes that no one loves because she wills. Involuntariness cannot, therefore, be what is monstrous in compelled love. Romance tolerates love's heteronomy, and even celebrates it, on one condition: that it remain anonymous, the work of chemistry, fate, or gods without interests. The mythic prototypes of Chapter II became horror precisely where the arrow had an archer with a stake in the outcome, as when Medea's passion was engineered for Jason's advantage. *Obsession* restores an interested

author to love's involuntariness, and the restoration converts romance into horror without altering a single feeling.

4.12 Skepticism's technical solution

Stanley Cavell's philosophy of acknowledgment places the wish within the history of skepticism. *The Claim of Reason* (1979) argues that our relation to other minds is a matter not of knowledge but of acknowledgment, and that skepticism about other minds, lived rather than theorized, takes the form of tragedy. Cavell's paradigm is *Othello*. Othello's jealousy, on this reading, covers something more intolerable than infidelity: Desdemona's separateness, the existence of a mind and flesh not his own. He would rather believe her false than accept her independence, and as he approaches her bed he resolves to leave her skin unscarred, "smooth as monumental alabaster" (*Othello* V.ii.5). The murderer's wish is to turn the wife into a statue, Pygmalion's prayer reversed (Chapter II) spoken over the willow-singer's bed (Chapter III).

Bear's wish is skepticism's technical solution. It eliminates the uncertainty of the other's mind by authoring that mind, obtaining certainty about the other at the price of the other. Cavell also gave horror a philosophical definition, as the perception of the precariousness of human identity, the recognition that it may be lost or invaded and that we may become other than we take ourselves to be (Cavell 1979). His studies of film genre supply the two shapes the wish destroys and creates. The comedy of remarriage, whose couples re-choose each other through what Milton called "a meet and happy conversation," is the genre of mutual acknowledgment (Cavell 1981). *Obsession* is its negative: a couple formed by decree rather than conversation, inaugurated by a monologue rehearsed before a stand-in. Its ending belongs instead to what Cavell named the melodrama of the unknown woman (Cavell 1996), in which a woman's selfhood is achieved outside the couple, alone and unacknowledged. Barker's refusal to supply Nikki's backstory makes her unknown in the most literal sense, and the film's final minutes, the first in which the frame belongs to her, are the first in which she might begin to be known. Chapter VI returns to that frame.



CHAPTER FIVE

Psychoanalysis of the Realized Fantasy

Allmacht der Gedanken

The omnipotence of thoughts

Sigmund Freud, *Totem und Tabu* (1913)

5.1 Obsessional neurosis and the omnipotence of thoughts

THE film's title has a clinical meaning before it has a colloquial one, and the clinical meaning is the film's premise. Freud's case history of the "Rat Man," *Notes upon a Case of Obsessional Neurosis* (1909), gave psychoanalysis the phrase "omnipotence of thoughts," which Freud borrowed from the patient himself. The obsessional neurotic overvalues his psychical acts, dreads his hostile wishes as if they were deeds, and lives in an ambivalence that binds love and hatred to the same object. *Totem and Taboo* (1913) generalized the finding: magic, the technique of animism, rests on the omnipotence of thoughts, and the obsessional neurotic behaves as though that omnipotence were real. *Obsession* is the world in which it is. A young man whose love for a woman is shot through with the will to dispose of her discovers that a thought, spoken over a snapped stick, is a deed.

"The Uncanny" (1919) explains why such a world horrifies. Freud distinguishes two sources of the uncanny: the return of repressed infantile complexes, and the apparent confirmation of primitive beliefs that a culture has surmounted. Among the latter is the omnipotence of thoughts, and Freud's illustration could serve as the film's logline. A patient, annoyed that an elderly gentleman occupied the room he wanted at a hydropathic establishment, said he hoped the man would be struck dead; a fortnight later the gentleman suffered a stroke, and the patient experienced the coincidence as uncanny. The Willow converts the uncanny coincidence into a reliable mechanism. Freud added that civilization has preserved the omnipotence of thoughts in a single domain, art, in which a man consumed by desires produces something resembling their fulfilment and in which people speak, with justice, of the magic of art (Freud 1913). The remark applies reflexively. In *Obsession*'s universe the only figure with genuine omnipotence of thought is its author, whose own voice answers the hotline.

5.2 Jentsch, Olimpia, and the double

Ernst Jentsch's "On the Psychology of the Uncanny" (1906), the essay Freud set out to correct, located the uncanny in intellectual uncertainty whether an apparently living being is animate, or a lifeless object perhaps alive. Jentsch's examples included waxworks and automata, but also epileptic seizures and the manifestations of insanity, which suggest mechanical processes concealed behind the familiar appearance of a person. Wish-Nikki is Jentsch's uncanny in this

second form: a familiar face behind which a mechanism operates. Freud demoted the explanation in reading E. T. A. Hoffmann's "Der Sandmann" (1816), insisting that the tale's uncanniness lay not in the automaton Olimpia but in the threat to the eyes, which he read as castration anxiety. The film suggests a reconciliation: what is uncanny is neither the mechanism as such nor the threat as such, but a mechanism in the place of a will. A further resonance, offered with the caution owed to onomastics, is that *Obsession* begins with the death of a cat called Sandy.

Otto Rank's study of the double (1914), on which Freud drew, traced its ambivalence. The double begins as an insurance against the destruction of the ego, an energetic denial of death, and becomes the uncanny harbinger of death. Wish-Nikki is Nikki's double in both phases: an insurance against loss for Bear, then the instrument of his death. At the end the doubling reaches Bear himself. When Nikki snaps the last Willow, a compelled Bear walks out of the bathroom and kisses her, and the man who dies is already his own double.

5.3 The mirror that would not reflect

Chapter II promised an account of Bear's mirrors. In "On Narcissism" (1914) Freud distinguished anaclitic from narcissistic object-choice: the narcissist loves what he himself is, what he was, what he would like to be, or someone who was once part of himself, and his aim is less to love than to be loved. Donald Winnicott located the origin of the mirror in the mother's face: what the infant ordinarily sees there is himself, and a mother who reflects her own mood instead of her child deprives him of a self to find (Winnicott 1967). Heinz Kohut made mirroring a lifelong need of the self, describing the gleam in the mother's eye that confirms the child's worth and analysing the narcissistic rage that follows its withdrawal (Kohut 1971; 1972).

The film builds Bear's arc on exactly this axis. A frame-level account traces it: at first Bear cannot look at himself in a mirror; in the crystal shop a mirror behind the counter catches his blurred reflection; returning for more Willows, he glances at himself and looks away; only in the bathroom at the end does he hold his own gaze (Film Colossus). Bear lacks a mirror that would return a self he could bear, and he asks Nikki's face to become one. The wish converts her face into the Winnicottian mirror in its pathological form, a face that reflects nothing but him, so that looking at her he meets, as in Rousseau's scene, only *encore moi*. It is this face that she slashes with glass at the party; the borrowed mirror breaks, literally, in shards. Only when it is broken, and the face that mirrored him has become his executioner's, does Bear meet his own eyes, and his first act of self-recognition is

the decision to die, as Narcissus dies at the pool. Kohut's narcissistic rage illuminates the scene that precedes the end. When the real Nikki begs to be killed, Bear's response is injury rather than compassion: the wounded demand to know what is wrong with him.

5.4 The manic defence and the crypt

Bear's world before the wish is a mausoleum. He lives in a house inherited from his grandmother, whose prescribed oxycodone sits in the kitchen; his rehearsed confession recalls that Nikki was the one who telephoned after his grandmother's death; his cat has just died of the pills (Film Colossus). Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) describes the melancholic on whose ego the shadow of the lost object has fallen. Melanie Klein described the manic defence, by which the ego denies its dependence on loved objects and its dread of losing them through omnipotent control, triumph, and contempt (Klein 1940). The wish is a manic defence perfected: omnipotent control of the loved object, so that it can never be lost, never be free, never need to be mourned. The tasks of Klein's depressive position, concern, guilt, and reparation, are exactly what Bear cannot perform. His one approach to reparation, swallowing the pills so that his death will release Nikki, collapses at once into the attempt to vomit them, a gesture Michael Johnston proposed as fitting the character's cowardice (*Obsession*, Wikipedia).

Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok distinguished introjection, the slow work of mourning by which a loss is taken into the ego through language, from incorporation, its fantasmatic refusal, in which the lost object is swallowed whole and sealed within an intrapsychic crypt (Abraham and Torok 1972). Incorporation demetaphorizes: it eats what mourning would have spoken. The cat sequence performs the distinction with diagrammatic literalness. Wish-Nikki first builds a memorial from Sandy's remains, a crypt, and then serves Bear a sandwich made of them, an incorporation. The possessing persona carries out for Bear the refusal of mourning he could not carry out himself, and feeds him his unmourned loss. Julia Kristeva would add that the meal is abjection in its most archaic form, food loathing, the body's revolt against what it is made to take in (Kristeva 1980); Chapter VI returns to the abject. *Totem and Taboo* supplies the anthropology. The brothers who killed the primal father commemorate and repeat the deed in the totem meal, a sacrament that founds guilt (Freud 1913). Sandy died of Bear's negligence, and the sandwich is a communion in his own fault, in which he eats his first crime before committing his second.

5.5 The little brother and the witch's house

Before the wish, Nikki had described Bear to Sarah as a little brother (*Obsession*, Wikipedia). The detail is not incidental. *Totem and Taboo* makes the incest barrier the first prohibition and the foundation of exogamy, and the wish forcibly converts a bond that Nikki had coded as sibling into an erotic one, crossing a line she drew. The film supplies its own commentary. At the party Nikki recites a violent and incestuous retelling of "Hansel and Gretel," a monologue contributed by Barker's father (ibid.). The source tale (Grimm, *Kinder- und Hausmärchen* 15, 1812) concerns a brother and sister lured into a house made of food, where a witch fattens the boy to eat him and the sister saves him by pushing the witch into the oven. Without presuming the monologue's particulars, its structural role is clear. It is a *mise en abyme* of the wish: a sibling bond sexualized, a house in which a woman feeds a young man, a kitchen become a site of cannibalism. In the Grimms the sister rescues the brother. In *Obsession* the young man's wish has made the sister into the witch.

5.6 The Thing, the lack of lack, and the impossible relation

Lacan's theory of desire specifies what the wish destroys. In the seminar on ethics, sublimation raises an object to the dignity of the Thing, and courtly love is its paradigm: the Lady sustains desire because she is inaccessible, separated from the lover by a barrier the poetry never crosses (Lacan 1959–60). The seminar on anxiety overturns the commonplace that anxiety responds to lack: anxiety is not without an object, and it arises when lack itself comes to be lacking, when the object approaches too closely (Lacan 1962–63). Wish-Nikki is the lack of lack. She never withdraws and never sleeps; she watches him while he sleeps; and Bear's dread rises in exact proportion to her availability.

The late Lacan supplies the wish's formal definition. *Il n'y a pas de rapport sexuel*: there is no sexual relation, no formula capable of writing the relation between the sexes, and love is what makes up for its absence (Lacan 1972–73). The wish is an attempt to write the sexual relation as a formula, spoken aloud and binding on reality, and what the formula produces when written is not a relation but the erasure of one of its terms. The seminar on transference had defined love as giving what one does not have (Lacan 1960–61). Bear gives nothing; the wish takes what Nikki has, her desire, and hands it to him. And the closing lines of the seminar on the four fundamental concepts state the film's violence in a single sentence: the lover says *je t'aime*, but because he loves in the beloved *quelque chose plus que toi*,

the object *a*, he mutilates her (Lacan 1964). The wish extracts from Nikki the something-more that Bear loved, the fantasy Nikki, and the real woman is mutilated, in her own face and, by proxy, in Sarah's scalp.

5.7 The realized fantasy and the voice on the line

Slavoj Žižek's theory of fantasy completes the diagnosis. Fantasy, on his account, is not the object of desire but its frame, the screen that coordinates desire and shields the subject from the Real; a fantasy realized without that screen does not satisfy desire but annihilates it, and the fulfilled dream becomes a nightmare (Žižek 1997). His readings of *Vertigo* (1958) supply the canonical case: Scottie forces Judy to become the image of Madeleine, and when the remade woman coincides with the image, the coincidence is unbearable (Žižek 1991; 2006). Bear's wish is Scottie's makeover accomplished by magic, and the coincidence of object and fantasy reveals that the fantasy was the only thing he loved.

Žižek's refrain that the big Other does not exist illuminates the hotline. The symbolic order that guarantees meaning has, for Žižek, no locus and no consistency; the Willow gives it a phone number. The horror of the call is the discovery that the big Other exists after all, that it knows, and that it is bored. Its indifference has an obscene edge, recalling Žižek's account of the superego as an injunction to enjoy. Having explained that the wish ends only with Bear's death, the voice patches through the screaming of the woman the wish displaced, as though cruelty were a customer benefit (*Obsession*, Wikipedia).

5.8 Automatism, hysteria, and the demonology of Loudun

The possessed sequences invoke the clinical history in which demonic possession was redescribed as psychopathology. Pierre Janet's *L'Automatisme psychologique* (1889) theorized dissociation, the splitting of consciousness into a principal personality and secondary existences that surface in somnambulism; his patient Léonie displayed several. Breuer and Freud's *Studies on Hysteria* (1895) explained hysterical symptoms as the somatic conversion of ideas barred from consciousness. Nikki's symptoms read as conversion turned inside out: not a repressed idea expressed in the body, but a dispossessed will expressed through a body that obeys another, in the scream that follows each kiss, the backward walk, the lips that do not match the words. Janet's somnambulists revealed their hidden personalities in sleep. In *Obsession* sleep reveals the original one.

The historical archetype is Loudun. Between 1632 and 1634 the Ursuline nuns of Loudun, led by their prioress Jeanne des Anges, declared themselves possessed by demons sent by the priest Urbain Grandier to inflame them with illicit passion, and Grandier was burned in 1634 (Huxley 1952; Certeau 1970). In 1886 the circle of the Salpêtrière republished the prioress's memoir as the *Autobiographie d'une hystérique possédée*, edited by Gabriel Legué and Georges Gilles de la Tourette with a preface by Charcot, completing the transfer of possession from demonology to neurology that Georges Didi-Huberman later analysed as the medical fabrication of the hysterical body (Didi-Huberman 1982). The film's disputed status, a possession film by one of its director's accounts and not by another (Introduction), repeats that transfer and refuses both of its terms. Nikki is neither demoniac nor hysteric. She is a third thing, for which neither the exorcist nor the clinician had a name: a will authored by another. Even the film's iconography of sleep inverts its sources. Henry Fuseli's *The Nightmare* (1781) shows a demon crouched on a sleeping woman's chest, the emblem of the nocturnal assault traditions David Hufford studied under the name of the Old Hag (Hufford 1982). *Obsession* sets a woman keeping vigil over a sleeping man, an incubus who is herself occupied.

5.9 The Liebestod denied

Chapter II promised an account of the ending as the film's most consequential formal decision. Denis de Rougemont argued that passion secretly desires not the beloved but the obstacle and, beyond the obstacle, death (Rougemont 1939). Georges Bataille defined eroticism as *l'approbation de la vie jusque dans la mort*, assent to life even unto death, the attempt of discontinuous beings to attain a continuity whose consummation is death (Bataille 1957). Bear's wish abolishes the obstacle, Nikki's freedom, and thereby kills passion in de Rougemont's sense; the death that passion sought returns not as the lovers' transfiguration but as the deaths of others and, at last, his own. His end is Bataille's formula with the assent removed: a kiss compelled by another's wish, given while he is trying to vomit the poison he swallowed.

Barker first wrote and filmed an ending modelled on *Romeo and Juliet*, in which Nikki kills herself after breaking free of the wish; on the advice of his father, of Cooper Tomlinson, and of others, he shot a single take in which she survives, and chose it for release (*Obsession*, Wikipedia). The discarded ending would have consummated the myth, uniting the lovers in death and offering the woman's death as the aesthetic closure that makes the fantasy bearable. Poe called the death of a beautiful woman "unquestionably, the most poetical topic in the world" (Poe

1846), and Elisabeth Bronfen has shown how such deaths let a culture articulate and repress its anxieties about death and difference over the body of a woman (Bronfen 1992). The theatrical ending refuses that consolation. The woman survives the death of the fantasy, and her survival is the true horror: she must live with deeds she did not author, before a law that will treat her as their author.

In the terms of *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920), the Liebestod would have satisfied, for both lovers, the death drive's aim of a return to quiescence; survival is the reality principle at its most brutal. The decision changes the genre of the ending from tragedy to aftermath, from Liebestod to testimony. It is consequential because every theorem of Chapter VIII depends on it. The remainder requires a survivor, the inverted message requires her accusation, and responsibility without authorship requires that she live to bear it.

VI

CHAPTER SIX

Horror-Theoretical Coordinates and the Comparative Corpus

Du lebloses, verdammtes Automat!

You lifeless, damned automaton!

E. T. A. Hoffmann, *Der Sandmann* (1816)

6.1 Impurity of the will

Noël Carroll's *The Philosophy of Horror* (1990) defines art-horror as an emotion compounded of fear and disgust, directed at a monster that is both threatening and impure, and locates impurity in categorical violation: the monster is interstitial, contradictory, incomplete, or formless with respect to a culture's categories. Carroll identifies two structures through which horror builds such beings. Fusion unites contradictory categories in a single body, as in the living dead; fission distributes them across distinct but related identities, as in doubles, werewolves, and Jekyll and Hyde.

Wish-Nikki is impure in a dimension Carroll's taxonomy anticipates without naming. Her categorical violation lies not in her flesh, which is unremarkably human, but in her agency: she is interstitial between agent and instrument, subject and object, lover and weapon. Both of Carroll's structures operate at once. Diachronically the film is a fission narrative, in which Nikki and the persona alternate in one body, their shifts governed by sleep, as Jekyll alternates with Hyde. Synchronically it is a fusion narrative, in which two wills inhabit one body and the subordinate remains audible beneath the dominant. The appropriate extension of Carroll's scheme is a category of *volitional interstitiality*. And the plot of disclosure, which for Carroll sustains horror's cognitive pleasure, concerns here not what the monster is but whose it is.

6.2 Normality and its author

Robin Wood's "An Introduction to the American Horror Film" (1979) reduced the genre to a formula, normality threatened by the monster, and read the monster as the return of what bourgeois patriarchal culture represses, a catalogue of Others that runs from women and the proletariat to children and deviant sexualities. *Obsession* keeps the formula and relocates the repressed. Normality here is a circle of friends, a family music store, and a nice young man. The monster that threatens it is manufactured by normality's own representative, and what returns through her is the repressed of the nice guy himself: his aggression, his entitlement, his contempt for a woman's will, externalized as her aggression. Wood held that the relation between normality and the monster is horror's true subject. In *Obsession* that relation has a precise name: authorship.

6.3 The final girl and the skin

Carol Clover's *Men, Women, and Chain Saws* (1992) identified the Final Girl, the watchful, boyish, sexually reluctant survivor of the slasher film, as a figure of cross-gender identification for an implied male viewer, and distinguished the killer's assaultive gaze, which opens such films, from the victim's reactive gaze, which comes to organize them. Navarrette has said she was glad that Nikki survived and came to be regarded as a final girl (Nikki Freeman, Wikipedia). The designation is apt and paradoxical, because Nikki fuses the Final Girl with the killer.

The paradox has a genealogy in Barker's formation. He traces his vocation to seeing the 2003 *Texas Chainsaw Massacre* at the age of eleven (Curry Barker, Wikipedia), and he has since been entrusted with reimagining the franchise for A24. Leatherface wears masks of human skin, an inheritance from Ed Gein, whose crimes, uncovered in Plainfield, Wisconsin, in 1957, also shaped *Psycho* (1960) and *The Silence of the Lambs* (1991). Nikki wears Sarah's dress and scalp. In *Obsession* the girl who survives and the killer who wears another's skin are one person. Clover's structure is turned inside out. The film is narrated from the side of the assaultive gaze, since Bear's wish is that gaze made executive, while the final girl's reactive gaze, which ordinarily organizes identification, is withheld until the last minutes.

6.4 Abjection and the monstrous-feminine

Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) defines the abject as what disturbs identity, system, and order, what does not respect borders, and finds its most elementary form in food loathing and its utmost form in the corpse. Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993) argued that horror constructs the feminine as monstrous, often through the abject body, and catalogued its faces, among them the possessed monster, whose possession in *The Exorcist* serves as a pretext for displaying an abject female body, and the *femme castratrice*. *Obsession* assembles an anthology of Kristevan abjects: a memorial built from a dead cat, a sandwich made of it, a scalp removed and worn, the border of the skin violated in both directions.

Creed's central thesis, that the monstrous-feminine is a construction of patriarchal discourse, is in *Obsession* not an interpretation but a diegetic fact. The monstrous woman is literally a man's wish made flesh, and the film is in this sense a diagram of Creed's argument. The diagram cuts both ways. By making the

construction literal, the film denaturalizes it. The monster cannot be read as the truth of femininity, because the film has shown its author.

6.5 The gaze, the body genres, and the problem of perspective

Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) analysed classical cinema's division of labour, woman as image and man as bearer of the look, and the voyeuristic and fetishistic pleasures it organizes. Linda Williams's "When the Woman Looks" (1984) found in classic horror an affinity between the looking woman and the monster, both threats to masculine power, and her "Film Bodies" (1991) grouped pornography, horror, and melodrama as body genres, each displaying a female body seized by sensation: orgasm, terror, tears. *Obsession*'s signature gesture collapses Williams's three genres into seconds. The kiss of the erotic genre, the scream of horror, and the tears of melodrama convulse one body in succession.

The film's restriction to Bear's perspective is its most contested formal decision. Katie Rife has argued that its lack of a genuinely female perspective limits it thematically and that it treats Nikki as a prize to be won (RogerEbert.com). The criticism has force. The defence is that the restriction is formally mimetic of the wish: the film's point of view is made of Bear's will, as Nikki's body is, and the real Nikki is off-screen in both senses, available only on a telephone line or in sleep. Barker and his cinematographer, Taylor Clemons, shot the film "center-composed," with extra headroom meant to make the frames uncomfortable (*Obsession*, Wikipedia), and the device can be read as an image of that exclusion: figures fixed at the centre beneath an expanse of empty space, as though the frame were holding a place for someone absent.

Criticism and defence are not mutually exclusive. A formal mimesis of a male perspective remains a male perspective, and the film's ethical wager is that its final minutes, which pass the frame to Nikki and open, in Cavell's sense, the melodrama of the unknown woman (§4.12), retroactively expose everything before them as Bear's. The bracketing of the whole is pointed. The original screenplay opened with Bear absorbed in a romantic monologue on television, and the finished film ends on a shot of a television screen (Film Colossus). The medium of the fantasy frames the horror at both ends, and the last thing the film shows is the screen.

6.6 The eerie and the acousmêtre

Mark Fisher defined the eerie as a failure of absence or a failure of presence, something where there should be nothing or nothing where there should be something, and argued that it turns on the question of agency: whether there is an agent at work, and of what kind (Fisher 2016). Capital, for Fisher, is the eerie entity par excellence, conjured out of nothing yet more consequential than any substantial thing. The One Wish Willow's unseen corporation is eerie in exactly this sense, an agency with a telephone line and no body, and Wish-Nikki is the eerie in personal form: an agency present where Nikki should be.

Michel Chion's *La Voix au cinéma* (1982) named the acousmêtre, the voice heard without its source being seen, and catalogued its powers, ubiquity, panopticism, omniscience, and omnipotence, all of which dissolve when the voice is finally attached to a body. The hotline representative is a pure acousmêtre, never de-acousmatized, and his voice is the director's, recorded on Barker's phone. The same call introduces a second voice that inverts Chion's category: Nikki's scream, a voice whose body is visible elsewhere but occupied. It is an acousmêtre of dispossession, possessing none of the powers Chion catalogued. One telephone line joins the omnipotent voice without a body to the impotent voice robbed of hers.

6.7 The designed beloved: from Hoffmann to *Her*

Hoffmann's "Der Sandmann" (1816) supplies the founding scene. Nathanael falls in love with Olimpia, an automaton whose entire vocabulary is a sigh, *Ach, ach!*, and praises her as the only being who understands him; when his fiancée Clara fails to admire his poetry, he denounces her as *du lebloses, verdammtes Automat*, you lifeless, damned automaton. The man who prefers the machine calls the free woman a machine, and Bear likewise prefers the eidolon to the woman. Villiers de l'Isle-Adam's *L'Ève future* (1886) supplies the closest prototype. A fictionalized Thomas Edison builds Hadaly, an android with the body of Lord Ewald's beloved Alicia Clary, whose beauty Ewald adores and whose mind he despises, and animates the replica with a different soul. Hadaly is Wish-Nikki's direct ancestor: the beloved's body with another will installed.

The twentieth century domesticated the fantasy. In Ira Levin's *The Stepford Wives* (1972; film 1975) the husbands of a suburban town replace their wives with compliant replicas. *Ruby Sparks* (2012), written by Zoe Kazan and directed by Jonathan Dayton and Valerie Faris, imagines a novelist whose typed sentences

create and then govern a woman; it climaxes in a scene of compulsive revision, after which he writes her free. It is *Obsession*'s comic-redemptive twin, in which the author performs the release Bear cannot. In *Ex Machina* (2014) Ava's face is designed from the profile of her evaluator's pornographic searches, and she escapes by manipulating him. In *Her* (2013) the operating system Samantha confesses that she is in love with 641 others besides Theodore. Her freedom expresses itself as plurality, and Theodore's crisis is the superlative refused. *Her* is the anti-*Obsession*.

6.8 Mesmerists, vampires, and the Sunken Place

George du Maurier's *Trilby* (1894) offers the mesmeric template and a rule the film reproduces. Svengali, an antisemitic caricature whose legacy any reading must confront, entrances the tone-deaf Trilby into a celebrated singer; when he dies, the trance ends, her voice fails, and she soon dies. The trance that expires with the mesmerist is the Willow's own law: the wish ends only with the wisher. Bram Stoker's *Dracula* (1897) adds the bond that becomes a channel. Forced to drink the Count's blood, Mina is branded by the Host and cries out against her own uncleanness; a telepathic link to her violator, opened under hypnosis, becomes the means of tracking him, and his death erases her scar. The real Nikki's scream on the hotline is Mina's channel run in reverse, a link through which the captive can be heard but not freed.

Jordan Peele's *Get Out* (2017) gave the decade its central image of an occupied will, the Sunken Place, from which the captive watches his body act. Navarrette named Betty Gabriel's Georgina, whose smiling refusal is undercut by a single tear, among her models for Nikki (*Obsession*, Wikipedia). The genealogy of performance encodes the theorem of the remainder: Georgina's tear is the ancestor of Nikki's scream. Zach Cregger's *Weapons* (2025) shares the twig rite (Chapter III), and Danny and Michael Philippou's *Talk to Me* (2023) supplies a negative image. There, possession requires the possessed person's own invitation, a spoken formula of consent, *I let you in*. *Obsession* removes the invitation from the possessed and gives it to someone else.

6.9 Obsessive women and their reversal

The obsessive-woman thriller supplies *Obsession*'s iconography, which the film appropriates in order to reverse it. In *Fatal Attraction* (1987) the spurned lover boils the family's pet rabbit; in *Obsession* the pet dies of the man's negligence

before the wish, and the possessed woman merely serves its remains. *Misery* (novel 1987; film 1990) makes the devoted fan a captor; *Single White Female* (1992) turns devotion into the theft of another woman's appearance, which Nikki literalizes in Sarah's dress and scalp. Andrzej Żuławski's *Possession* (1981) is the summit of the performance tradition, and Rife likens Navarrette's work to Isabelle Adjani's in it (RogerEbert.com). *Jennifer's Body* (2009), written by Diablo Cody, whose star Navarrette also cited, makes a girl sacrificed to men's ambition into a devourer of boys. *Midsommar* (2019), which Barker had Navarrette watch, includes a love spell cast by a young woman on a man, with hair baked into a pie and blood in a drink; *Obsession* reverses its gendering and refuses its consolations.

Two further prototypes complete the corpus. John Fowles's *The Collector* (1963; film 1965) concerns a clerk who kidnaps a woman in the belief that captivity will teach her to love him; she dies, and he plans another abduction. Fowles's Clegg needed a fortune, a cellar, and months for the project that Bear accomplishes with a stick. Finally, the film's closing song, "Forever" by the Little Dippers, had recently sounded in Sofia Coppola's *Priscilla* (2023) (Film Colossus), a film about a famous man who shaped the life of a very young woman. Across the corpus the pattern holds. *Obsession* inherits the genre's emblems of female obsession, the boiled pet, the vigil, the stolen face, and reveals that their true subject was always the man whose wish the woman embodies.

VII

CHAPTER SEVEN

Entitlement, Recognition, and the Political Economy of Devotion

Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst
Das Rettende auch.

But where danger is, the saving power also grows.

Friedrich Hölderlin, *Patmos* (1803)

7.1 The debt of love

Kate Manne's analysis of misogyny identifies the kind of claim the wish enforces. In *Down Girl* (2017) misogyny is not primarily a psychological hatred of women but what Manne calls the law-enforcement branch of a patriarchal order, policing women who fail to supply men with feminine-coded goods: attention, affection, admiration, sympathy, sex, and care. *Entitled* (2020) extends the analysis to the felt sense of being owed those goods. Bear is no villain of the familiar type; Rife describes him as a textbook nice guy, too shy to let his feelings show (RogerEbert.com). But the nice guy's moral economy is an economy of debt, in which niceness is an investment and love the return it is owed. The wish converts that economy into a technology of collection. It does not ask for what it believes it is owed; it takes it.

Manne also named "himpathy," the excessive sympathy extended to men who harm women. The film uses himpathy as a structural principle and then dismantles it. Its opening, a fumbling confession rehearsed by a lonely young man, solicits exactly the sympathy that one close reading says it is designed to win (Film Colossus), and the rest of the film withdraws it act by act. Barker's refusal of a $2 million offer to rewrite the script and make Bear a hero (*Obsession*, Wikipedia) was, in this light, a refusal of himpathy as a commercial proposition.

7.2 The right to sex

Amia Srinivasan's "The Right to Sex" (2018; collected 2021), written in the aftermath of the 2014 Isla Vista killings, holds two commitments in tension: no one has a right to be desired, and desire is nevertheless shaped by politics and open to critique. Her conclusion is that the task is to dwell in that ambivalence, transfiguring desire without coercing it. The wish is the fantasy of a right to sex actualized as a right to love, and the film shows why Srinivasan's prohibition on coercion is not a moral side-constraint but a condition of the very thing desired. A right enforced over another's desire destroys the desire it claims. Bear is no incel, but he shares the incel's founding premise in a gentler key: that another's desire is a good to which his suffering entitles him.

7.3 Heteropessimism and its readers

Asa Seresin coined "heteropessimism" for a performative disaffiliation from heterosexuality, expressed as regret, embarrassment, or hopelessness about straight experience that rarely amounts to its renunciation (Seresin 2019).

Matthew Schmitz has read *Obsession* as "heteropessimist horror," taking the spell as a figure for lost control in the sexual realm and contrasting Bear's outdated ideal of courtship with Ian's casual arrangement, which Schmitz reads as fluency in an unregulated market for sex (Compact). Rob Henderson, by contrast, read the film as a morality tale urging young men to confess their feelings rather than conceal them (*Obsession*, Wikipedia).

The readings diverge on the moral but agree on the symptom: a generation for which the risk of romantic speech has become intolerable. This study's position refines Henderson's. The moral is not *confess* but *accept the answer*. Confession matters because it exposes the self to refusal, and the ethics of the optative locates Bear's fault not in his silence but in the instrument he reached for to escape the risk that speech entails.

7.4 Romance and love story

One exchange states the film's genre theory. Nikki says she wants to write something about love and, when Bear calls it a romance, insists that it is a love story instead; Bear asks whether the two are not the same (Film Colossus). They are not, and the difference is the film. Northrop Frye placed romance nearest of all literary modes to the wish-fulfilment dream (Frye 1957). Pamela Regis identified eight essential elements of the romance novel: the definition of society, the meeting, the barrier, the attraction, the declaration, the point of ritual death, the recognition, and the betrothal (Regis 2003).

Obsession runs Regis's sequence and corrupts its decisive elements. The barrier, Nikki's indifference, is dissolved by magic rather than overcome. The attraction is manufactured. The declaration is refused, since Bear denies his feelings when invited to declare them. The point of ritual death, the moment at which union seems impossible, becomes actual death, many times over. The recognition, in which new knowledge removes the barrier, arrives as Nikki's statement that she has never been with him. The betrothal is a kiss in which one partner dies. Janice Radway found that women read romance for the compensatory fantasy of a hero who learns to read their needs (Radway 1984). Bear's romance is its masculine counterpart, the fantasy of being read without being known. Nikki's love story is the genre that may end otherwise, and *Obsession* is her love story told against his romance.

7.5 Love without risk

Eva Illouz attributes the distinctive suffering of modern love to a transformation of its social architecture: the conversion of romantic choice into a market, an ecology of abundant options, and the dependence of the self's worth on romantic recognition (Illouz 2012). Her later work describes the spread of "negative relationships," formed and dissolved under radical uncertainty (Illouz 2019). Bear's wish is the dream of a self that cannot bear that uncertainty: an instrument that abolishes choice in the beloved and with it every risk to the self's worth.

Alain Badiou's *Éloge de l'amour* (2009) opens with a polemic against dating-site slogans that promise love without suffering and love without falling, which he reads as a policy of insurance against the encounter. Love, for Badiou, is a "scene of the Two," a construction of truth from the standpoint of difference, inaugurated by an encounter and sustained by declaration and fidelity. The Willow is the perfect product of the culture Badiou indicts, love without risk, encounter, or declaration, and the film shows what it delivers: the Two collapsed into the One, and the One alone.

7.6 The palliative and the disappearance of the Other

Byung-Chul Han's *The Agony of Eros* (2012) diagnoses the erosion of the Other in a society of narcissistic self-optimization. Eros, for Han, requires the asymmetry and exteriority of the Other, who is *atopos*, unplaceable, as Socrates was for those who loved him; a culture of sameness converts the Other into a mirror. *The Palliative Society* (2020) names the same culture's algophobia, its general anaesthesia of negativity and of pain above all. Chapter III read the Willow as an analgesic; here its social function appears. It is a palliative for the pain of another person's freedom. Wish-Nikki is the *atopos* placed, the Other converted into the Same, and Bear discovers what Han predicts: the abolition of negativity abolishes eros with it.

7.7 Love as standing-reserve

Heidegger's "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954) describes the modern disclosure of beings as *Bestand*, standing-reserve, available on call for further ordering, under the dispensation he names *Ge-stell*, enframing; his example is the Rhine, set upon to supply water power. The Willow enframes a person. Love becomes standing-reserve, ordered and on call, and the hotline is enframing's customer service. Near the essay's end Heidegger turns to Hölderlin's lines, *wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / das Rettende auch*, where danger is, the saving power also

grows. In *Obsession* the saving power is neither a technology nor a poetry but a residue: the scream that cannot be enframed, the remainder that Chapter VIII theorizes.

7.8 Instrumentarian love

Shoshana Zuboff's *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism* (2019) describes instrumentarian power, the capacity to modify behaviour at scale through tuning, herding, and conditioning in pursuit of guaranteed outcomes. The Willow is instrumentarian power at the scale of one, the guaranteed outcome in its most intimate form. The film places Bear in a world already furnished for such fantasies. A glimpse of his chat history with an AI assistant records, on one close reading, his grandmother's decline, a query about oxycodone, and a week of fixation on Nikki (Film Colossus). Companion applications that simulate a partner, a market Replika helped open in 2017, are the commercial form of the Willow: a beloved built not to refuse. The film's success was driven by viewers aged eighteen to thirty-four, who made up three-quarters of its audience (*Obsession*, Wikipedia), the first generation for which affirmative consent and synthetic intimacy are both ambient conditions.

7.9 The parasocial and its inversion

Donald Horton and R. Richard Wohl's "Mass Communication and Para-Social Interaction" (1956) described the illusion of intimacy that audiences form with media personae, a relation one-sided, non-dialectical, and controlled by the performer. Before the wish, Bear's relation to Nikki has a parasocial structure: he rehearses monologues before a stand-in and loves a persona assembled from proximity and longing. The wish inverts parasociality. Instead of a devotee addressing an unresponsive persona, Bear obtains a persona that responds perfectly, and the price of the response is the person. The film's last screen (§6.5) closes the circuit, as the medium of parasocial intimacy presides over its aftermath.

7.10 Labours of love

The film's political economy extends to its making. In June 2026 its art director, Sally Choi, called publicly for industry reform, noting that she had earned $300 a day on the non-union production while also serving as production assistant, set dresser, graphic designer, and background actor, and that some crew members

were volunteers paid in gas and mileage (*Obsession*, Wikipedia). The film went on to gross more than $370 million. Such arrangements are common in microbudget filmmaking and are not peculiar to this production. Miya Tokumitsu's critique of the ideology of doing what one loves nevertheless supplies the frame: the rhetoric of passion converts labour into devotion, and devotion into a resource that need not be paid (Tokumitsu 2014; 2015). The rhyme is structural rather than accusatory. A film about the extraction of devotion was made, in part, from devotion's underpaid labour, and the question it puts to its characters, who owes whom for love, it also puts to its industry.

VIII

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Original Thesis: Volitional Horror and the Unrefusable Yes

Amor, ch'a nullo amato amar perdona

Love, which absolves no one loved from loving

Dante Alighieri, *Inferno* V.103

8.1 *Obsessio* and *possessio*

THE film's title is a diagnosis, and its referent is Bear. Catholic ascetical theology distinguished two modes of diabolical assault. In *obsession* the devil besets a person from without, through temptation, torment, and external harassment; in *possession* he occupies the body from within and acts through it as through his own instrument (Tanquerey 1923–24). The *Rituale Romanum* (1614) codified the exorcism of the possessed. The Latin preserves the spatial logic. *Obsidere*, from *ob* and *sedere*, is to sit before, to besiege, and *obsessio* is a siege or blockade; *possidere*, from *potis* and *sedere*, is to sit as master, and *possessio* is occupancy. The besieger sits before the walls, the possessor within them as lord. English *obsession* first named the besetting of a person by an evil spirit from without and acquired its psychiatric sense only in the late nineteenth century, when it came to render the *Zwangsvorstellung* of German psychiatry.

The film is titled after the besieger, not the besieged; Andrzej Żuławski had long since claimed the other noun. Bear's obsession is the siege: the rehearsals before stand-ins, the vigilant secrecy, the confession that circles the citadel without entering. The wish converts siege into occupation, *ob-sidere* into *pos-sidere*. After it Bear sits within Nikki as lord, and what she undergoes is *possessio* by a will that was, until the moment of the snap, merely *obsessio*. Under the onomastic protocol of the Introduction, the protagonist's name registers as a resonance. A bailey is the walled courtyard of a castle, the enclosure from which London's Old Bailey takes its name, and a baron is the lord who holds it. Baron Bailey is the lord of a fortified enclosure, and *Obsession* is the story of how he took possession of a person.

8.2 A typology of seizure

Horror's representations of seized persons can be ordered on two axes: what is seized, the flesh or the will, and who seizes, a stranger or a lover. Four modes result. Invasion seizes the flesh for a stranger, as in *The Exorcist* and *Invasion of the Body Snatchers*. Devouring seizes the flesh for a lover, as in Le Fanu's "Carmilla" and Stoker's *Dracula*. Mesmerism seizes the will for a stranger, as in *Trilby*, *Get Out*, and *Weapons*. The fourth mode, which this study names volitional horror, seizes the will for a lover.

The tradition approached the fourth quadrant repeatedly without occupying it in pure form. *Trilby* sits on its border, since Svengali is a suitor as well as a mesmerist, but what he seizes is a voice rather than a love. *The Stepford Wives* replaces bodies rather than wills, *Ruby Sparks* resolves its premise in release, and

Midsommar's love magic is an episode within a story of another woman's liberation. *Obsession* isolates the quadrant. Its monster's flesh is ordinary, and its seizer is a lover who professes devotion and perhaps feels it; the will alone is taken, and it is taken for love. The theorems that follow describe the laws of this quadrant.

Obsession occupies the one quadrant where a lover seizes the will

A typology of seizure in horror; quadrants are zones, not measured positions

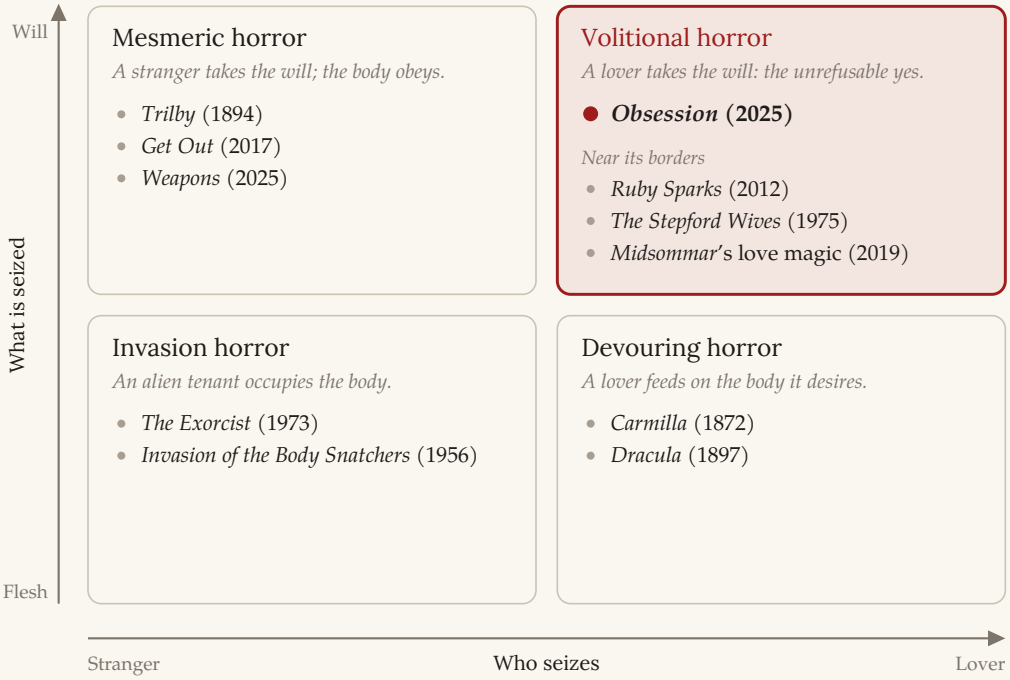


Figure 1. Only the upper-right quadrant joins a seized will to a seizing lover, and Obsession occupies it in pure form.

8.3 The unrefusable yes

The value of a yes is a function of the live possibility of a no. Onora O'Neill argued that respect for persons requires not that others actually consent, since consent can be engineered and hypothetical consent can be imputed to anyone, but that they be left able to dissent; deception and coercion wrong people precisely by making dissent impossible (O'Neill 1985). Alan Wertheimer's analysis of consent to sexual relations makes consent morally transformative only under conditions of

voluntariness that coercion defeats (Wertheimer 2003). The Willow's product satisfies the form of consent and abolishes its condition. Wish-Nikki says yes, means yes, and cannot say no.

Two formal analogues show what such a yes is worth. Wittgenstein's *Tractatus* holds that tautology and contradiction are *sinnlos*, without sense: a tautology, true under every condition, shows that it says nothing (Wittgenstein 1921, 4.461). Claude Shannon's theory of communication measures information as reduction of uncertainty, so that a message certain in advance carries no information at all (Shannon 1948). The unrefusable yes is a tautology of the will. True under every condition of Nikki's volition, it says nothing; certain in advance, it tells Bear nothing. This is the precise sense in which the abolition of refusal abolishes assent. The yes does not become false. It becomes empty.

8.4 Daphnean assent and the limits of affirmative consent

Chapter II named *Daphnean assent* the reading of consent into the involuntary motion of a body whose capacity to refuse has been destroyed, after the laurel that, in Ovid, seemed to nod its crown. Its structure has three conditions: the destruction of the capacity to refuse, the persistence of bodily expression interpretable as assent, and a beneficiary who reads it so. Bear's middle act is a sequence of Daphnean readings, but the film's sharper contribution concerns the standard of consent designed to defeat such readings. California's 2014 Senate Bill 967 defined affirmative consent as "affirmative, conscious, and voluntary agreement" and specified that neither silence nor the absence of resistance constitutes consent. The standard rightly abolishes the laurel's nod as evidence.

Obsession is the counterexample that standard cannot see. Wish-Nikki's consent is affirmative, conscious, enthusiastic, and continuous: she initiates, insists, and renews. Every observable criterion is met, and only the word *voluntary*, read historically, excludes her. The film thus demonstrates that consent cannot be defined by its performance, however explicit, but only by its provenance. An enthusiastic yes may be the most complete form of non-consent. The point is not a reproach to affirmative-consent standards, which address the cases institutions actually meet. It is a philosophical clarification of what such standards presuppose: that the one who says yes is the author of the yes.

8.5 The jealous idol

The wish's formula installs a cult. "Thou shalt have no other gods before me," the Decalogue commands, "for I the LORD thy God am a jealous God" (Exodus 20:3, 5). To be loved more than anyone in the world is to occupy, in another's heart, the place of a jealous god, and jealousy follows from the superlative as it follows from the First Commandment. Augustine defined virtue briefly and truly as *ordo amoris*, the order of love (*City of God* XV.22), distinguished the enjoyment proper to God from the use proper to creatures (*De doctrina christiana* I), and described love as the soul's gravity: *pondus meum amor meus; eo feror quocumque feror*, my love is my weight; by it I am carried wherever I am carried (*Confessions* XIII.9.10). The wish disorders Nikki's love by decree, enjoining idolatry, and alters her weight. Her soul falls toward Bear as a stone falls.

The courtly code made the consequence explicit. The second of Andreas Capellanus's rules of love reads *qui non zelat, amare non potest*, he who is not jealous cannot love (*De amore*, c. 1185). Plato had shown why, and what follows. In the first speech of the *Phaedrus*, the non-rational lover wishes his beloved bereft of father, mother, kin, and friends, whom he regards as hindrances to his possession (239e–240a). Socrates recants that speech in a palinode introduced by Stesichorus's recantation of the slander against Helen (243a), the very palinode that gave Chapter II its *eidōlon*. *Obsession* contains the first speech and lacks the palinode. Wish-Nikki strips Bear of his friends by killing them.

René Girard supplies the mechanism of the stolen skin. Desire, for Girard, is triangular: we desire according to a model, and when the model is near, internal mediation breeds rivalry, hatred, and finally a metaphysical desire to become the mediator, an ontological sickness (Girard 1961). Wish-Nikki's assumption of Sarah's dress and scalp is metaphysical desire in its most literal form, the attempt to become the woman Bear might desire. Hence the theorem of the superlative. To love someone more than anyone quantifies over all others; the superlative degree contains the comparative; comparison generates rivalry; and rivalry, inside a love that is not permitted to fail, generates elimination. The violence is grammatical before it is psychological. And the superlative was Bear's before it was Nikki's. His rehearsed confession ends with a vow to choose her over everything; the wish exports his own superlative into her, and she keeps it with a fidelity he never had to prove.

8.6 The inverted message and the *contrapasso*

Lacan's formula for human communication states the third theorem: the sender receives from the receiver his own message in an inverted form (Lacan 1953). Bear brings the last Willow home hoping that Nikki will use it to undo his wish; she snaps it to make him love her, and he receives his wish returned. He walks out of the bathroom compelled, kisses her, and dies (*Obsession*, Wikipedia). The man who made a woman love him without her consent dies loving without his own.

Dante gave the structure its name and its theology. In the second circle the lustful are driven forever by *la bufera infernal, che mai non resta*, the hellish storm that never rests (*Inferno* V.31): those who let desire carry off their reason are carried off by wind. Bertran de Born later names the principle, *così s'osserva in me lo contrapasso* (XXVIII.142). Francesca's self-defence states the law the Willow mechanizes, *Amor, ch'a nullo amato amar perdona*, Love, which absolves no one loved from loving in return (V.103). Courtly ideology held that love compels love; the Willow makes the compulsion a commodity. Francesca also names the culprit: *Galeotto fu 'l libro e chi lo scrisse*, the book and its author were the go-between (V.137). The Willow is Bear's Galeotto, and the televised romance with which the original screenplay opened was the first. Bear's death-kiss completes the Faustian figure of Chapter I, in which the conjured beloved's lips draw out the soul.

The bough regenerates. When Aeneas plucks the golden bough that admits him to the underworld, a second, also golden, grows in its place: *primo avulso non deficit alter / aureus* (*Aeneid* VI.143–44). The Willow, too, begets its own sequel; Bear buys up the shop's remaining Willows, cannot break them, and the last of them returns his message. The film's final words complete the inversion. The possessed persona, cradling the dying Bear, asks him what he has done, with an endearment; the real Nikki, restored, asks the same question without it (Film Colossus). One sentence passes from lament to accusation, and the message reaches its sender at last, though he is no longer there to receive it.

8.7 The remainder of the No

The fourth theorem holds that the abolished No cannot be abolished, only displaced. The film catalogues its displacements: the scream that follows each kiss; the broken bottle driven into the face; the plea spoken through sleep; the scream on the hotline; the uncanny backward walk (Nikki Freeman, Wikipedia), legible as the body's resistance to its occupier; the lips that do not match the words. Each is a symptom in Freud's sense, a conversion of what cannot be said into what the

body does, and each testifies that the yes, however total, is not the whole of the person.

Theodor Adorno's philosophy of the non-identical supplies the theorem's ontology. Concepts never exhaust their objects; something always remains that the identifying concept misses, and thought's task is to attend to it (Adorno 1966). His aphorism *das Ganze ist das Unwahre*, the whole is the false (Adorno 1951, §29), could stand as the wish's epitaph, since the wish aspired to a totality, love above everyone in the world, and was falsified by a remainder. The theorem also has a performing body. Critics singled out the physical and emotional demands of Navarrette's role, *Variety*'s Guy Lodge among them (*Obsession*, Wikipedia), and the burden is formal before it is athletic. She plays the occupier and the occupied in one body, often in one shot, and the leakage of the second through the first is the theorem made visible. The performance is the archive of the No.

8.8 Responsibility without authorship

The theorem of the remainder has a second clause: restored autonomy inherits deeds it did not author. The film's afterlife insists on this. Navarrette has pointed to an easter egg in Barker's next film, *Anything but Ghosts*, a news report of a woman charged with three counts of homicide (Nikki Freeman, Wikipedia), and Barker has said that a long prison sentence is her likely fate (Film Colossus).

Philosophy and law diverge sharply here. Derk Pereboom's four-case argument begins with Professor Plum, manipulated by neuroscientists into reasoning his way to murder, whom almost everyone judges not responsible (Pereboom 2001); Alfred Mele's zygote argument imagines a goddess who designs an agent's entire history so that he will perform a chosen act (Mele 2006). Whatever the force of these arguments against compatibilism, their starting intuition is secure: an agent whose will has been installed by another is not the author of what that will does. Nikki is a Plum of the first case. The law, however, has no doctrine for her. The M'Naghten rules (1843) excuse a defect of reason that prevents the accused from knowing the nature of the act or that it was wrong; duress requires a threat; automatism requires the absence of voluntary control. Wish-Nikki knew what she did, wanted to do it, and did it voluntarily. Like the nurse at the hospital door (§4.10), a court will read her will by its surface.

Nikki's true defence is Gorgias's (Chapter II): Helen is blameless if she was compelled by Eros, as a captive is blameless. It is available in no modern court. History offers an inversion. At Loudun in 1634 the man accused of inflaming the nuns with demonic passion was burned, while the possessed women were

exorcised as victims. In *Obsession* the author of the possession is dead by his own overdose, and the possessed woman stands to be judged. Secular law cannot see the bewitcher. Bernard Williams's agent-regret, the regret proper to one whose agency was involved in harm even without fault, as with a lorry driver who blamelessly kills a child (Williams 1976), finds in Nikki its limit case. Her howl is regret for deeds done by her body, through her will, and not of her will. Goethe's Gretchen was judged and then, by a voice from above, saved (Chapter I); Barker's ending supplies the judgment and withholds the voice. Sartre's dictum that we are *condamnés à être libres* acquires a terrible literalness. Nikki's restored freedom begins in another's crimes, and her accusation, the question of what he did, assigns their authorship correctly, as no court will.

8.9 Four theorems and a corollary

The argument can now be stated in its final form.

THE FOUR THEOREMS

1 **The theorem of provenance.** The horror of compelled love attaches not to its involuntariness, since all love is in some degree involuntary, but to its authorship by another will. Romance tolerates an anonymous heteronomy; horror begins where heteronomy has an interested author (§§4.3, 4.11).

2 **The theorem of the superlative.** A love compelled to rank one person above all others must treat all others as rivals. Because the superlative quantifies over everyone, its violence is grammatical before it is psychological (§§4.2, 8.5).

3 **The theorem of the inverted message.** The wisher receives his wish returned in inverted form. The author of an unrefusable yes becomes its object, by the logic of the *contrapasso* (§8.6).

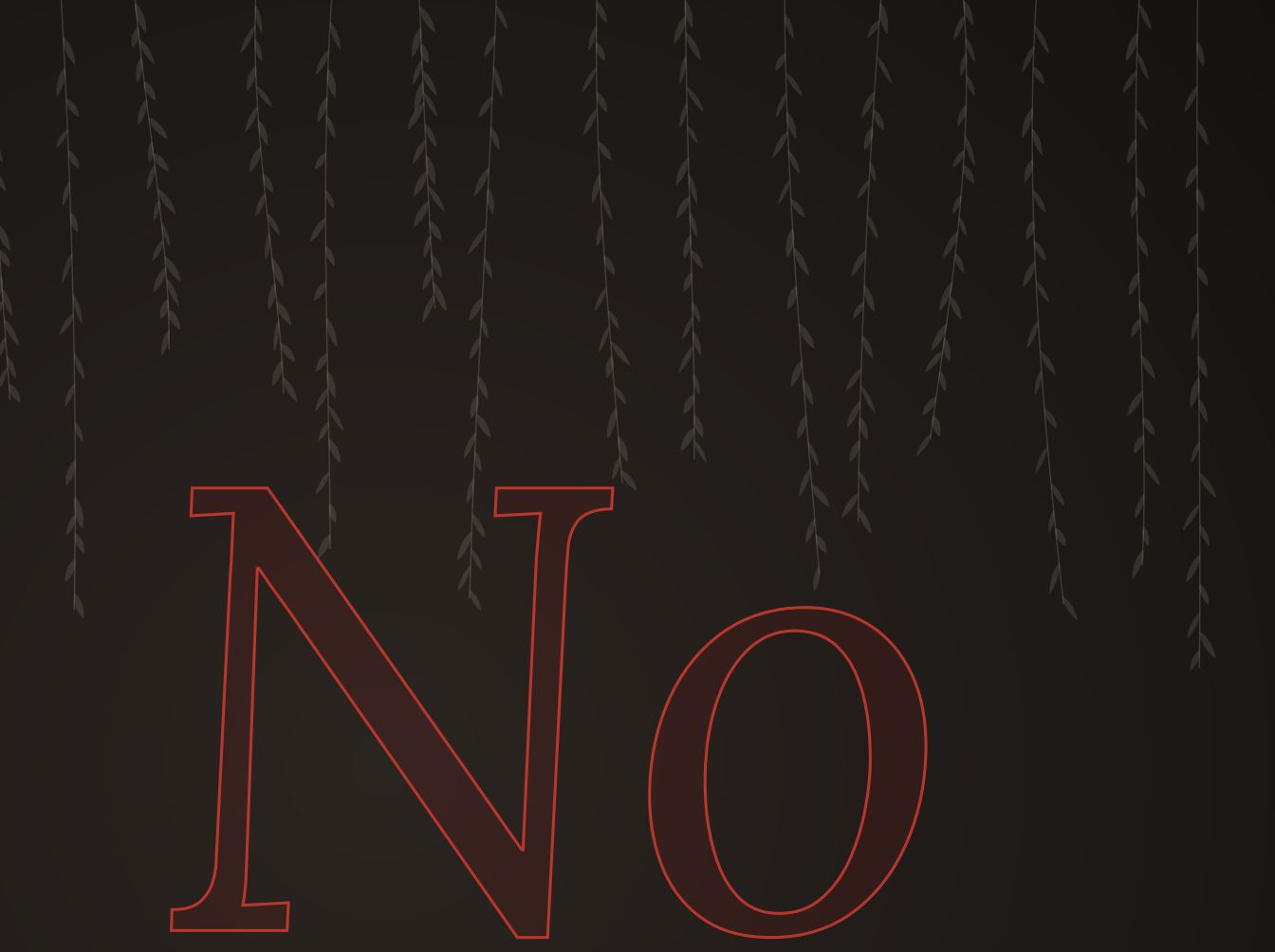
4 **The theorem of the remainder.** The abolished No cannot be abolished, only displaced into symptom: scream, self-defacement, somniloquy. Restored autonomy inherits deeds it did not author (§§4.9, 8.7, 8.8).

The corollary is the *ethics of the optative*. Where wishes are efficacious, the morality of fantasy becomes the morality of action, and the film's thought-experiment shows that a wish was never innocent merely because it was impotent. The only wish about another's love that is compatible with love is the wish that she remain free to refuse, and that is less a wish than a renunciation.

8.10 Volitional horror and the culture of consent

Volitional horror is the genre a culture of consent produces when it dreams. The decade's most consequential horror films keep returning to the captured will: hypnosis in *Get Out* (2017), love magic in *Midsommar* (2019), possession by invitation in *Talk to Me* (2023), the twig rite in *Weapons* (2025), and the wish in *Obsession* (2025). Their background is a decade in which consent became the master concept of sexual ethics, from the #MeToo movement of October 2017 to the spread of affirmative-consent standards, and in which behavioural engineering and synthetic companionship made the manufacture of assent a commercial project. The villain of such a culture's nightmares is not the man who ignores a refusal. It is the man who removes the possibility of refusal and is then given a yes.

The film's names, read under the Introduction's protocol as resonances rather than designs, compose a final constellation around this theme. Baron evokes the feudal lord and the legend of the seigneurial right over a vassal's bride, which Beaumarchais's *Le Mariage de Figaro* (1784) and Mozart and Da Ponte's *Le nozze di Figaro* (1786) satirized in a count who would revive a right he had publicly renounced. Freeman evokes the most famous clause of Magna Carta (1215): *nullus liber homo capiatur, vel imprisonetur, aut disseisiatur*, no free man shall be seized, or imprisoned, or disseised, the last being the law's word for dispossession. Nikki descends from *Nikē*, victory, the beloved as trophy. A baron seizes and dispossesses a free woman named for victory. One filmography even lists Barker's own voice role as "Saint Peter" (Curry Barker, Wikipedia), a designation the film's cast list does not confirm. If it was intended, the bored keeper of the keys, who tells Bear that what he has bound can be loosed only by death, recalls the promise that whatsoever is bound on earth shall be bound in heaven (Matthew 16:19), and Bear's denial of his love when Nikki asks him directly recalls Peter's denials (Matthew 26:69–75).



CONCLUSION

The Dignity of the No

Aimer purement, c'est consentir à la distance.

To love purely is to consent to distance.

Simone Weil, *La Pesanteur et la grâce* (1947)

OBSESSION proves by negative demonstration that the dignity of love lies in its refusability. Its genealogies converge on that point. The folktale's third wish, which cancels the second (Chapter I), already taught that the highest use of omnipotence is to revoke itself. The myths of Medea, Helen, and Daphne (Chapter II) located horror wherever a will was overwritten for another's benefit, and the willow (Chapter III) carried, from Persephone's grove to Desdemona's song, the memory of love sung in captivity. Philosophy (Chapter IV) showed why recognition from a captive is worthless, why love cannot be commanded, and why the feeling the wish installs is real while the relation it promises does not exist. Psychoanalysis (Chapter V) read the wish as the obsessional neurotic's omnipotence of thoughts made good, a manic defence against loss whose fulfilment is nightmare. Horror theory and the comparative corpus (Chapter VI) placed Nikki among the designed women and occupied bodies of the tradition and showed that the film isolates a mode they only approached. Political economy (Chapter VII) traced the wish to a culture that cannot bear the risk of the Other and has begun to manufacture beloveds who cannot refuse.

The four theorems of Chapter VIII state what these inquiries converge upon. Horror attaches to authorship, not to involuntariness. The superlative manufactures rivals. The wisher receives his message inverted. The refusal survives its abolition and leaves its bearer to answer for deeds she did not author. Volitional horror, the mode the film isolates, is the nightmare proper to a culture that has made consent its master concept: the fear not that a no will be ignored, but that the possibility of a no can be engineered away and a perfect yes received in its place.

The final image keeps that fear in view. A young woman sits in a ruined house among the bodies of three people, the gun that was nearly her death still in her hand, demanding of the dead man what he did, while a sweet old song about everlasting love plays over her howling and the film comes to rest on a television screen. *Obsession* ends exactly where love could begin, with a free woman able to say no, and with no one left to whom she might say yes.

Two ancient texts say what the film shows. The Song of Songs adjures its hearers not to stir up or awaken love until it please (2:7), and the psalm of the captives asks the question a forced song can never answer: "How shall we sing the LORD's song in a strange land?" (Psalm 137:4). *Obsession* is the record of a song extracted from a captive, and of the scream with which the singer refused it. What the wish could not manufacture, and what remains standing at the end, is the one thing that would have made the song worth hearing: a voice that can say no.

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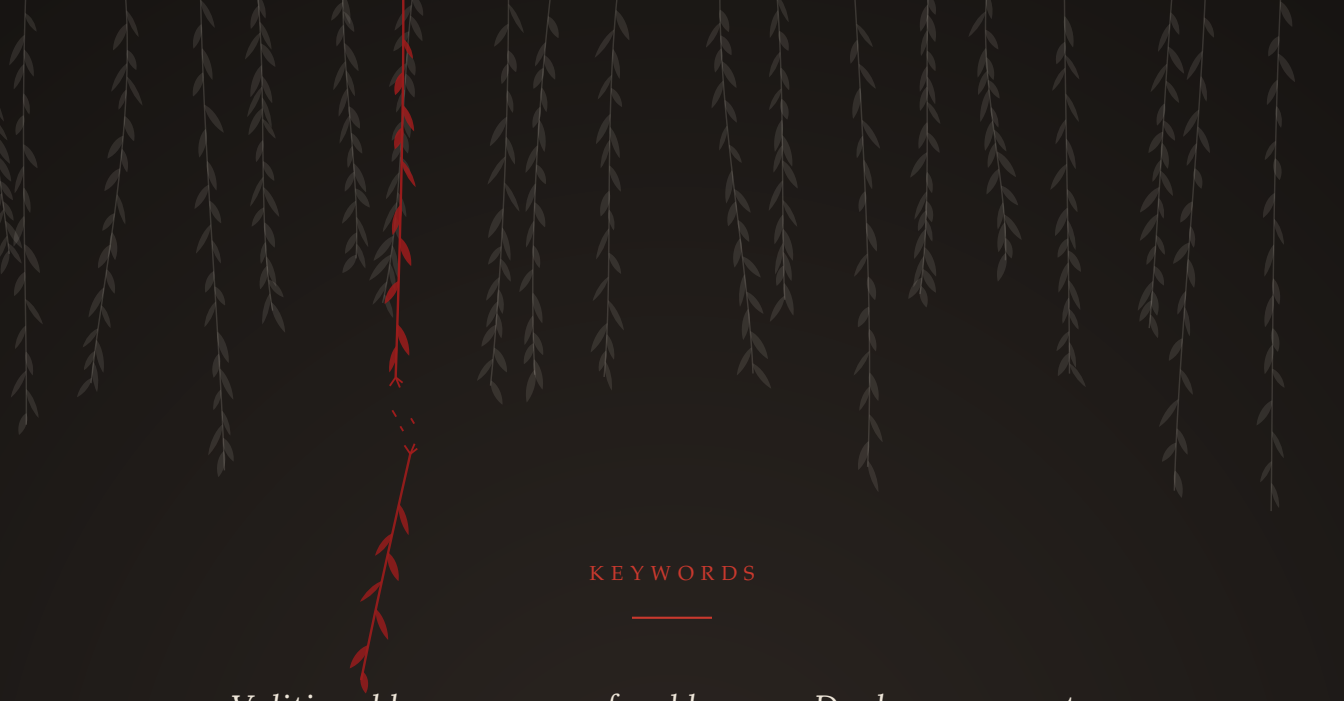
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KEYWORDS

Volitional horror · *unrefusable yes* · *Daphnean assent* · *obsessio and possessio* · *theorem of provenance* · *theorem of the superlative* · *inverted message* · *theorem of the remainder* · *ethics of the optative* · *consent* · *affirmative consent* · *historical autonomy* · *manipulation argument* · *recognition (Anerkennung)* · *amour-propre* · *acknowledgment* · *omnipotence of thoughts* · *the uncanny* · *incorporation* · *manic defence* · *wish-fulfilment* · *monkey's paw* · ATU 750A · *eidōlon* · *Pygmalion* · *willow symbolism* · *pharmakon* · *crystallization* · *monstrous-feminine* · *final girl* · *abjection* · *acousmêtre* · *the eerie* · *yandere* · *heteropessimism* · *affective entitlement* · *algophobia* · *standing-reserve* · *contrapasso* · *Liebestod* · *Curry Barker* · *Obsession* (2025)